



Northumberland
National Park

Northumberland National Park

Local Plan

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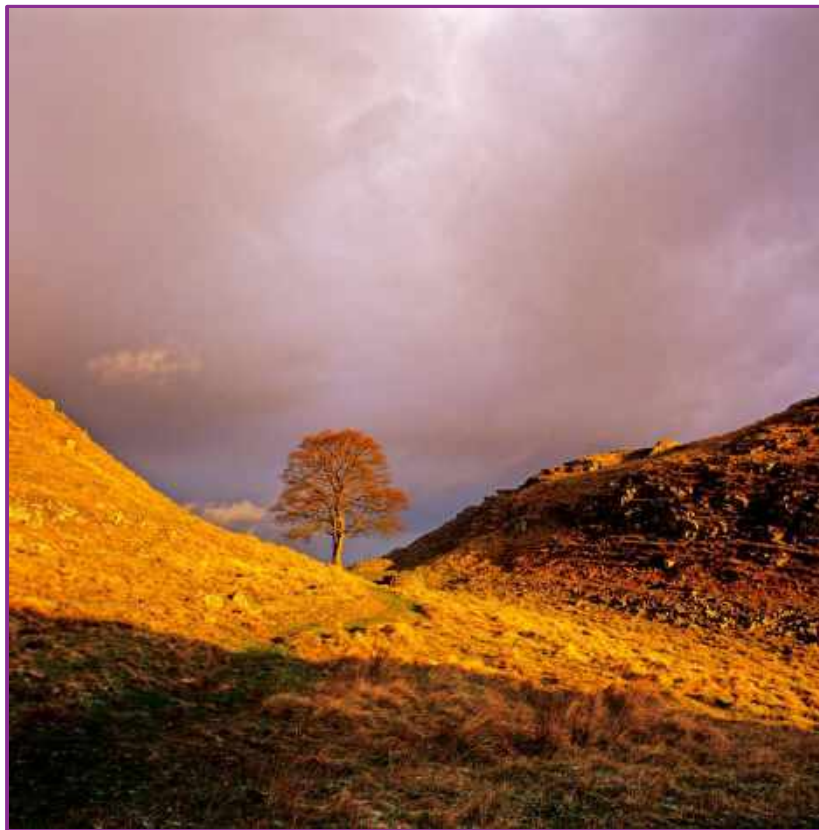
Foreword

For the past three years, we have engaged with Northumberland National Park's communities, businesses, organisations and stakeholders, and gathered evidence which has helped to shape our new Local Plan.

Northumberland National Park Authority ('NNPA' or 'the Authority') would like to thank all who took part, for the positive and constructive responses which have helped us to understand how our local communities see Northumberland National Park developing in the future.

Through the plan, we have set out our policy approach for sustainable development, setting out the overall spatial strategy for Northumberland National Park to 2037, guiding where new homes, workplaces, services and facilities are needed.

Through the policies in our Local Plan, we will help shape the future of the National Park for the benefit of all who live, work and visit this unique and tranquil part of Northern England whilst conserving the rich culture, heritage and landscape we all know, love and respect.



Sycamore Gap, Hadrian's Wall © Roger Clegg, NNPA.

1. Introduction

What is the Local Plan?

- 1.1 The Local Plan contains policies, proposals and supporting text that sets out what type of development is and isn't acceptable in the National Park. It also sets out a vision for the Park and a strategy to achieve this through planning decisions over a specific period of time. The Local Plan is our first consideration when we make a decision on a planning application and its policies are likely to affect you, your community, the businesses you use and land in your local area. Local Plans form part of the Development Plan for the area and are prepared by the Local Planning Authority. Neighbourhood Plans, as and when made/adopted, also form part of the Development Plan and are prepared by the Local Community. Together they form the statutory framework for future development of land and buildings.
- 1.2 This Local Plan, adopted on the 15th July 2020, replaces the Core Strategy and Development Policies document. These documents and the policies in them are superseded and not in place any more. The two adopted Supplementary Planning Documents (SPD), the Building Design Guide and Landscape Strategy, will need updating and the Authority will start this after adoption of the Local Plan. The Authority acknowledges that they will be out of date on adoption of this Local Plan. In the meantime (between adoption of this Local Plan and adoption of updated SPDs) the Authority will still refer to the SPD guidance as it contains much important and relevant detail.
- 1.3 The Northumberland National Park Local Plan (2017-2037):
 - Sets the strategic planning policies for the National Park, taking account of key factors like population trends, economic growth, climate change, resources and environmental character;
 - Directs the scale and distribution of new development (such as housing and employment) which is required to meet the National Park's identified need to 2037;
 - Provides the planning principles, including detailed 'development management' policies to guide decisions on planning applications;
 - Shows key environmental designations and include site specific proposals for the conservation and enhancement of historic and natural assets.
- 1.4 Planning law stipulates that planning applications should be determined in accordance with the Development Plan unless material considerations indicate otherwise. Therefore, the policies within the Northumberland National Park Local Plan, together with those in neighbourhood plans, will be the starting point for the assessment of all planning applications. The Local Plan must comply with the Government's National Planning Policy Framework (or 'NPPF') and associated Government legislation. It also sits underneath frameworks and strategies produced regionally and sub-regionally, including the Strategic Economic Plan for the North East prepared by the North East Local Enterprise Partnership (or 'NELEP').

Duty to Cooperate

- 1.5 A 'Duty to Cooperate' was introduced through the 2011 Localism Act and it is incorporated into the NPPF. It places a legal duty on local planning authorities and public bodies to cooperate on strategic planning issues that cross administrative boundaries. Local planning authorities must demonstrate how they have complied with the duty at the independent examination of their Local Plans. The Duty requires the Authority to:
- Work with neighbouring authorities on a joint approach to sustainable development or use of land, where there would be a significant impact on both/all of the local planning areas concerned;
 - Set out planning policies to address such issues;
 - Work with a range of public bodies to set out agreements on how strategic issues will be dealt with through the plans of each;
 - Consider joint approaches to plan-making.
- 1.6 Following the recent agreements on the North of Tyne Devolution Deal (between Northumberland County Council, Newcastle City Council and North Tyneside Metropolitan Borough Council) and the commencement of a Borderlands Growth Deal (with local authorities either side of the England/Scotland border), the Authority will be working more closely with these neighbouring authorities.
- 1.7 The Duty also covers key statutory or representative bodies such as Homes England, the Water Authority, Natural England, Historic England and the Environment Agency. From time to time, 'position statements' and/or 'statements of common ground' will be prepared and agreed between the Authority and these various parties as necessary. A joint Statement of Common Ground between the National Park Authority and the County Council has been finalised for the submission of the Local Plan to the Secretary of State.

Linkages to other policies, plans and programmes

- 1.8 The government published its [8-point plan for National Parks](#) in England in 2016. This set out the government's ambition and strategic priorities for England's National Parks and a framework for their delivery which was intended to feed into the government's [25 Year Environment Plan](#). This was published on 11 January 2018 and set out government action to help the natural world regain and retain good health. It aims to deliver cleaner air and water in our cities and rural landscapes, protect threatened species and provide richer wildlife habitats. It calls for an approach to agriculture, forestry, land use and fishing that puts the environment first.
- 1.9 The National Park Local Plan is broadly aligned with both of these overarching strategies. It is also aligned with the vision, strategic aims, outcomes and objectives contained within the [Northumberland National Park Management Plan \(2016-2021\)](#) a proportion of which have been taken forward and incorporated within the vision, strategic priorities and spatial objectives contained within the Local Plan.

What influences the Local Plan?

- 1.10 This Plan is not written in isolation. In addition to technical work carried out to inform its contents it is expected to help deliver or work alongside the aims and objectives of other plans, policies and statutory responsibilities. In particular:

- **The Statutory Purposes and Duty** – The two statutory purposes¹ of National Parks are:
 - 1) *‘to conserve and enhance the natural beauty, wildlife and cultural heritage of the National Park’* and;
 - 2) *‘to promote opportunities for the understanding and enjoyment of the special qualities of the Park by the public’.*
- In addition, there is a statutory duty on the National Park Authority, in pursuing these purposes *‘to seek to foster the economic and social well-being of local communities’* and *shall for that purpose co-operate with local authorities and public bodies whose functions include the promotion of economic or social development within the area of the National Park.*
- Legislation requires that these public bodies and local authorities must also take account of the statutory National Park purposes - *‘In exercising or performing any functions in relation to, or so as to affect, land in a National Park, any relevant authority shall have regard to [National Park] purposes’.* In practice this means that this Local Plan must assume a policy of restraint and protection, based upon the need to fulfil the first purpose, and it must also make sure that the Park can be enjoyed and appreciated for its special qualities. In the event of any potential conflict between the two statutory purposes the first takes precedence (known as the Sandford principle).
- **The Northumberland National Park Management Plan** – This is a statutory requirement² and the overarching plan for the Authority and its partners with an interest and role in the future of the National Park. It sets out policies for the management of the National Park and defines the ‘special qualities’ that are referred to in the second National Park purpose. It was last updated in 2016 and is due for review every five years.
- **The National Planning Policy Framework (NPPF) and Planning Practice Guidance (PPG)** – The NPPF, produced by the Ministry of Housing, Communities and Local Government is the main statement of Government planning policy and, together with its accompanying online practice guidance sets out the expectations of central government as to what a local plan should aim to deliver. The NPPF (2019) sets out a ‘presumption in favour of sustainable development’ at paragraph 11, unless policies in the framework indicate that development should be restricted – for example because land is designated as a National Park.
- **The English National Parks and Broads Circular 2010** – This circular was produced by the Department for the Environment, Food and Rural Affairs (DEFRA) and sets out the government’s vision for National Parks. The most relevant section is Section 4 covering National Park statutory purposes, climate change, securing a diverse and healthy natural environment and maintaining vibrant, healthy and productive living and working communities.
- **An Eight Point Plan for England’s National Parks 2016** – This sets out the Government’s intention to protect, promote and enhance National Parks over a four year period (2016-2020) and is part of its wider ambition to improve the environment as set out in the 25 year

¹ Section 5 of the National Parks and Access to the Countryside Act 1949, as amended by Section 61 of the Environment Act 1995.

² Section 66 of the Environment Act 1995

plan published in 2018. Although the plan does not specifically mention the statutory planning function of National Park Authorities, several of its points are partially fulfilled through successful implementation of planning policy.

- **The 25 Year Environment Plan, 2018 – “A Green Future”** sets out future government action on improving the natural environment, including cleaner air and water, protecting threatened species and an environmentally led approach to agriculture, forestry, land use and fishing. It also includes actions on waste and soil degradation, climate change and opening up the mental and physical health benefits of the natural world to people from the widest possible range of ages and backgrounds.

Research and evidence

1.11 A series of technical reports (collectively known as the evidence base) that underpin this Local Plan have been published, including a:

- **Sustainability Appraisal (May 2019)** which has assessed all policies in this Plan to see if they are the best means of delivering development which strikes the right balance between environmental, economic and social objectives;
- **Landscape Character Assessment Update (June 2019)** which categorises landscapes into particular types, describes their features, overall character and sets out how sensitive they may be to new development;
- **Habitats Regulation Assessment or HRA (May 2019)** which is undertaken to make sure the Authority's policies do not have any harmful impacts on the designated interest features of European wildlife sites;
- **Strategic Flood Risk Assessment (Level 1 2010; Level 2 2015)** which looked at whether any particular areas of the National Park are susceptible to flooding;
- **Strategic Housing Market Assessment or SHMA (May 2017)** which looked at housing need and demand;
- **Strategic Land Availability Assessment or SHLAA (May 2019)** which looked at available land for housing, and the likelihood of it coming forward for development;
- **Local Plan Viability Assessment (May 2019)** and Addendum Report (August 2019) which looked at whether policies are setting any requirements that would prevent new development from being delivered;
- **Infrastructure Plan (September 2017)** which reviewed the capacity of existing infrastructure covering the National Park; and
- **Economic Futures and Employment Demand Study (May 2018)** which assessed the likely future need for economic development in the National Park.

1.12 All of the above technical reports are available to download on the NNP website at:
www.nnp.org.uk/localplan.

Using this Plan

It is important that the Plan is read as a whole. Several policies may apply to one proposal but to help keep the document concise, cross referencing of policies is only used where another policy is directly relevant. All policies and any neighbourhood plans should be considered where they are relevant to a particular development proposal.

Throughout this Plan, unless stated otherwise, where policies contain separate criteria all criteria are intended to apply.

- 1.14 The Local Plan includes 'Strategic (ST)' Policies that are intended as 'scene setting' policies and indicate the guiding principles that will be at the forefront of decision makers' minds when it comes to assessing the appropriateness of new development at the planning application stage. Other policies then provide more detailed 'Development Management (DM)' policy on how planning applications will be assessed. Strategic policies are also separated out as they are the ones that any future neighbourhood plan would need to be in 'general conformity' with. This does not mean they carry greater status and all policies in this Plan carry equal weight within the planned system.



Housesteads Crags, Hadrian's Wall © Roger Clegg, NNPA.



Hareshaw Linn waterfall © *David Taylor, NNPA*.

2. Spatial Portrait

- 2.1 Northumberland National Park is deeply rural in its nature. With a resident population of fewer than 2,000 spread over 1,049 square kilometres, its population density is the lowest in England at 2 persons per square kilometre (ONS).
- 2.2 The largest single settlement is Elsdon, located in the east of the National Park, with a population of around 240 (2011 Census). Other key settlements include Alwinton, Charlton, Falstone, Greenhaugh, Harbottle, Holystone, Ingram, Kirknewton, Lanehead, Rochester, Stannersburn and Stonehaugh. Much of the National Park's population resides in these settlements, smaller villages and hamlets, as well as isolated houses and farmsteads.
- 2.3 The larger 'gateway' settlements, including Bellingham, Haltwhistle, Rothbury and Wooler are more populous, however these settlements are located outside of the National Park boundary meaning that only a fraction of their parish populations are resident within the Park.
- 2.4 This Local Plan covers the whole of the National Park area. The purpose of the Local Plan is to provide consistency and clarity for local development decision-making, in the determination of planning applications. Local plans are also important in the delivery of sustainable development.
- 2.5 The Local Plan review follows the work already done in 2015-16 on the review of the National Park Management Plan. The Management Plan (2016-2021), adopted in March 2016, is a partnership document setting out how the statutory National Park purposes and the Northumberland National Park Authority's socio-economic duty will be delivered. It was prepared by representatives of local business, landowners, local communities and delivery agencies, and translates the local issues facing the National Park into 40 specific objectives for the Authority and its partners to deliver. The Local Plan is a delivery mechanism for some of the Management Plan objectives, as well as a mechanism to deliver the wider requirements of the planning system as set out in the National Planning Policy Framework³.

³ National Planning Policy Framework, Department for Communities and Local Government, February 2019. The Government's planning policy for England and the framework for local policy making.

Map of Northumberland National Park Location⁴



⁴ This publication includes mapping data licensed from Ordnance Survey © Crown Copyright and database right 2019. Ordnance Survey 100022521.

Current planning challenges facing Northumberland National Park

- 2.6 The National Park is facing a variety of challenges and aims to address these through planning policy. The first challenge is population decline. The population of Northumberland National Park is 1,951 people (2015, ONS), a decline of 2.2% since 2011 when the population was 1,993.
- 2.7 Further, over the 2001–2014 period, the profile of the National Park’s population has aged, with the proportion being in the older age groups (65+ years) increasing relative to those in the younger age groups increasing from 16% to 24%⁵. Evidence⁶ also indicates that there is a clear need for affordable housing in the National Park. Analysis of affordable housing requirements evidenced an overall imbalance (shortfall) of 40 affordable dwellings over the Plan Period 2017–2037 and an imbalance (shortfall) of 2 dwellings each year, with most of this need at 61.8% for 1 and 2 bedroom dwellings and 38.2% for 3 or more bedroom dwellings. This is not a target for delivery but expresses the overall need from the Housing Register compared with current supply of affordable housing. This indicates a clear need for family housing, elderly accommodation and housing for working-age residents.
- 2.8 Inter-Department Business Register (IDBR) data indicates that within the National Park boundary the number of businesses fell by 9% between 2009 and 2012 but recovered slightly in 2012. It also indicates that local employment fell by 14% in the same period. The latest Census data suggests that the Northumberland National Park has a very small ‘working age’ population of less than 1,600 people with a particularly high proportion of whom are employed in skilled trade occupations (26%). There are also a relatively high proportion of people with elementary occupations and relatively few people with administrative, sales, customer service, caring, leisure and other service occupations compared to both the National Park and national averages. Northumberland National Park also has the highest concentration of agricultural businesses of all English National Parks⁷. However, the percentage of residents employed in farming and forestry has declined from 28% in 2001 to 22% in 2011⁸.
- 2.9 More recent evidence suggests that employment in the National Park declined by 37% between 2006 and 2016 – this is in stark contrast to the growth in jobs recorded at the national and regional level over the same period. Connectivity is a key challenge for the local economy at present. Road connectivity and public transport access is relatively poor, with a number of local businesses viewing this as a cause of recruitment difficulties⁹.
- 2.10 Local wages are also low in relation to house prices. Despite relatively low unemployment, there is still a need to broaden the range of jobs and business opportunities to improve quality of life and maintain people and services in the area. If farming continues to decline as a local employer as is anticipated, the Local Plan helps identify more opportunities for agricultural diversification which make use of the assets available within farm businesses and rural estates.
- 2.11 In common with other sparsely populated rural areas, the National Park continues to lose its community facilities. Increased centralisation of health services, education, jobs and retail provision is having detrimental consequences for local communities and the wider attractiveness of the area

⁵ Northumberland National Park Demographic Forecasts 2016

⁶ Northumberland National Park Strategic Housing Market Assessment (2017)

⁷ Valuing England’s National Parks (National Parks England 2013)

⁸ State of the National Park Report 2015

⁹ NNP Economic Futures and Employment Demand Study (2018)

for new families to live. The Local Plan, therefore, encourages the development of new services and protection of existing ones.

- 2.12 Reliance on broadband communication becomes even more important when other services are declining, yet high-speed broadband and mobile phone coverage is patchy (at-best) across much of the National Park. The Local Plan supports the provision of new broadband and mobile telecommunication infrastructure where it can be accommodated without serious harm to the National Park's special qualities.
- 2.13 There are no properties within the National Park that are connected to the national gas grid with approximately 10% of properties not being connected to mains electricity. The National Park's housing stock is older, frequently under-occupied and inefficient in energy use. The expense of adequately heating homes in the National Park has a negative impact on quality of life for households.
- 2.14 The National Park needs to remain attractive and relevant to future visitors to support the local economy. This means encouraging existing visitors to keep returning, and attracting new visitors by offering accommodation and facilities that meet their needs.
- 2.15 Fundamental changes to the climate continue to be predicted during this century. The local planning system has a role to play by steering development into locations that support existing infrastructure and communities without consuming excessive non-renewable resources. Another role of planning is to steer development away from flood risk areas and to try to slow rainfall run-off and reduce downstream flooding. Planning decisions should also help to ensure the resilience of new and existing development to extreme weather event risks such as flooding, wild-fires and the effects of climate change.
- 2.16 The long-term challenge of maintaining and enhancing the area's landscapes, wildlife and the conservation of its historic assets will continue. This Plan aims to increase the reuse of buildings, which could support conservation and produce social and economic benefits. This Plan also provides an opportunity to do more to enhance biodiversity and maximise the benefits provided by natural capital and its associated ecosystem services. The Local Plan helps meet these challenges by:
- supporting the development of appropriate non-allocated land,
 - encouraging the re-use of brownfield land and existing buildings and,
 - supporting and promoting the provision of new community facilities and infrastructure such as improved telecommunications.
 - protecting existing infrastructure, community facilities and rural services.
 - conserving and enhancing landscapes, wildlife and historic assets.
- 2.17 The Local Plan is more specific about its aims and objectives but less rigid than the previous Plan about the means of achieving them. It does this by including policies that allow more flexibility for applicants and decision-makers to decide how the desired outcomes will be reached rather than prescribing negatively-worded policies that rely on restrictive criteria to minimise harm.
- 2.18 Whilst this could be viewed as potentially creating more development risk than has previously been the case in policy making, it should be noted that approved rates for planning applications are currently very high in the National Park (97% in 2018/19). The policies are based on evidence

and have been scrutinised by a planning inspector before adoption. The Plan must also deliver consistent decisions and be seen to be fair by all users of the planning system. It must continue to deliver development that will not prejudice National Park purposes and will take opportunities where possible to enhance its landscape, wildlife and cultural heritage.

- 2.19 The Local Plan sets out the planning strategy for the National Park over the next 20 years. The National Planning Policy Framework (NPPF) sets clear expectations as to how a Local Plan must be developed in order to be justified, effective, consistent with national policy and positively prepared to deliver sustainable development that meets local needs and national priorities. The most appropriate approach to positively planning for development in the National Park will differ from that taken in areas with a larger, more certain, demand. Demand in the Park is generally small in scale and unpredictable, therefore it is considered unsuitable for the Local Plan to allocate land for specific uses. Consequently, rather than planning ahead for a specific quantum of development, the Local Plan incorporates sufficient flexibility to facilitate 'windfall' development opportunity as and when needs arise, while protecting other public interests such as landscape character, neighbouring amenity, public safety and ecological value.

Strategic Environmental Assessment

- 2.20 Local Plans are required to be tested via Strategic Environmental Assessment. The purpose is to test the likely environmental impact of alternative policy options. Assessment is a continuous process that informs the Plan up until it being presented to a planning Inspector for formal examination. This Strategic Environmental Assessment process has been incorporated into the more holistic Sustainability Appraisal (SA) exercise¹⁰ undertaken in accordance with section 19 of the Planning and Compulsory Purchase Act 2004. This Local Plan has also been informed by previous appraisals undertaken for the Issues Paper (spring 2017), Policy Options Paper (autumn 2017), Preferred Options Draft Plan (July 2018) Publication Draft Plan (summer 2019) and Submission Draft Plan (Sep. 2019) which are available to view on the National Park Authority's website at www.nnp.org.uk/localplan.

Habitats Regulation Assessment

- 2.21 The Plan is also subjected to a Habitats Regulation Assessment. This is a statutory requirement of the European Habitats Directive to determine whether the Plan might have a significant effect on internationally-designated sites. If a significant effect is likely or cannot be ruled out, then the Plan proceeds to Appropriate Assessment to determine whether there would be any adverse effect on site integrity. Given the outcomes of the latest assessments this Plan will not have any significant impact on European sites.

¹⁰ The process of weighing and assessing policies for their global, national and local sustainability implications in relation to the environment, the economy and society, incorporating a Strategic Environmental Assessment (SEA) to comply with EU Directive 2001/42/EC.

3. Vision, Strategic Priorities and Spatial Objectives

National Park Purposes

- 3.1 Northumberland National Park was designated in 1956 to benefit the whole nation. Its particular purposes are set out in Section 61 of the Environment Act 1995:
- to conserve and enhance the natural beauty, wildlife, and cultural heritage of the national parks;
 - to promote opportunities for the understanding and enjoyment of the special qualities [of the national parks] by the public¹¹.
- 3.2 In delivering these two statutory National Park purposes the Authority also has a duty to 'seek to foster the socio-economic wellbeing of local communities within the National Park'. Consequently, as well as delivering sustainable development, the Local Plan aims to avoid outcomes that would prejudice the purposes for which the National Park was designated.
- 3.3 The Northumberland National Park is a part of the cultural and natural heritage of the nation. It is a working landscape; its natural beauty influenced by centuries of farming and other human activity. It contains important heritage assets, wildlife species, habitats and geological diversity, much of which is recognised as being of national or international importance, and is protected by law.

Special Qualities

- 3.4 National policy gives great weight to the protection of the Special Qualities of the National Park, such as its landscape, wildlife and cultural heritage. The Special Qualities of Northumberland National Park are set out in the Management Plan. The 2016 Management Plan identifies these as:
- Distinctive Landscape Character
 - Rich Cultural Heritage
 - Landscape Rich in Biodiversity and Geology
 - True Sense of Tranquillity.
- 3.5 Where a development proposal would create conflict between the two statutory purposes, the purpose of conservation is given preference. This is a long-standing presumption known as the 'Sandford Principle', which has been repeated most recently in Government Circular advice on National Parks published in 2010¹². Experience indicates that 'Sandford' conflicts tend to be very rare in the Northumberland National Park. Where they have been encountered, it has usually been possible to resolve the conflict through negotiation and the use of conditions or management agreements attached to a planning permission.

¹¹ If there is a conflict between the two, then the 'conservation' purpose takes precedence – this is known as the 'Sandford' principle. More detailed government guidance about the implementation of National Park purposes including aspects of planning policy, are set out in the 2010 Circular 'English National Parks and The Broads'.

¹² DEFRA (2010) English National Parks and the Broads: UK Government Vision and Circular

Our Vision

- 3.6 In March 2016 a new National Park Management Plan¹³ was adopted following 11 months of public consultation and discussion. The Plan was prepared by a partnership of 14 organisations representing landowners, local representatives and public bodies. Its aim is to deliver actions that will keep the National Park a thriving place to live and work in and to visit. We think that it makes sense to include the same 20 year vision in the Local Plan. The Local Plan is one of the key delivery mechanisms for achieving the objectives set out in the Management Plan.

'Northumberland National Park will be a truly welcoming and distinctive place, easily accessible to all. Its inspiring and changing landscapes, characterised by open spaces, tranquillity, diverse habitats, geology and rich cultural heritage, will be widely recognised and valued. The living, working landscape will contribute positively to the well-being of the thriving and vibrant communities in and around the Park.'

- 3.7 The Management Plan (2016-2021) outlines five strategic aims to achieve this vision, these are:

Aim 1 – A Welcoming Park: To put people and their connections with the landscape at the heart of the National Park.

Aim 2 – A Distinctive Place: To manage, conserve and enhance the distinctive natural and cultural qualities of the National Park.

Aim 3 – A Living Working Landscape for Now and the Future: To adapt to change by applying new approaches, together with traditional techniques.

Aim 4 – Thriving Communities: To ensure the thriving and vibrant communities have a strong sense of place and an economy grounded in the natural and cultural qualities of the National Park.

Aim 5 – A Valued Asset: To ensure the National Park is valued as a local, regional and national asset, with influence beyond its boundaries that is worth looking after now and for generations to come.

- 3.8 These aims have been translated into strategic priorities and spatial objectives for the Local Plan.

¹³ Northumberland National Park Management Plan 2016 - 2021. A partnership document that sets out how the statutory National Park purposes and social economic duty will be delivered.

Strategic Priorities

3.9 The strategic priorities for the Local Plan were set out in the Issues Paper as follows:

Strategic Priority 1: To support sustainable development and land management that conserves and enhances the National Park's distinctive natural and cultural qualities and protects its assets.

Strategic Priority 2: To support sustainable use of ecosystem products and services thereby enhancing natural capital across the landscape of the National Park, contributing positively to health and wellbeing.

Strategic Priority 3: To support and encourage sustainable economic growth to allow our local communities to thrive.

Strategic Priority 4: To support the provision of a range of housing that encourages more working age people and families to live in the National Park or one of its gateway settlements.

Strategic Priority 5: To support the retention and enhancement of community facilities, infrastructure and rural services in order to sustain our thriving communities.

3.10 The above strategic priorities were broadly supported by public consultation already undertaken (spring 2017 and autumn 2017) and have formed the basis (alongside the vision and Management Plan aims) of a set of spatial objectives for the Local Plan.

Strategic Spatial Objectives for the Local Plan

1. Support locally-sustainable development that will improve the National Park as a high quality place to live, work and visit.
2. Support development that will maintain existing services, infrastructure and community facilities or develop new ones for the benefit of local communities.
3. Support sustainable land management that conserves and enhances the National Park's distinctive natural and cultural qualities and protects its assets.
4. Support the sustainable use of ecosystem services and natural capital.
5. Encourage development that will support a growing, sustainable, diverse and resilient local economy, to help make the National Park (and its gateway settlements) a more attractive option for young adults and people of working age to live and work in.
6. Use the planning system to help deliver the statutory National Park purposes of: conservation and enhancement of natural beauty, wildlife and cultural heritage; and, the promotion of opportunities for the understanding and enjoyment of the Special Qualities of the National Park by the public.
7. Encourage development in locations with the best access to existing services and facilities, and where it will not be vulnerable to the impacts of climate change or will increase resilience to it.
8. Support innovative, high-quality and more sustainable building design that complements the distinctive character of the National Park.
9. Ensure the landscape of the National Park continues to be responsive and resilient to change while at the same time conserving and enhancing its character.

4. Strategic Approach

Spatial Strategy

- 4.1 An important part of Plan making is determining where future development will go. This is referred to as the 'spatial strategy'. The intention is to deliver development in places that are more sustainable than the alternatives would be. Typically this means encouraging development in the locations that already have existing infrastructure capacity like public transport, community facilities and public services such as waste collection, health services and schooling. Spatial strategies typically try to minimise the loss of greenfield land because of its long term, alternative potential for food production, biodiversity, landscape value or recreational use.
- 4.2 The National Planning Policy Framework (NPPF) states that the purpose of the planning system is to contribute to the achievement of sustainable development which can be summarised as meeting the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs¹⁴.
- 4.3 Local Plans are required to comply with government policy as set out in the National Planning Policy Framework (NPPF). The framework includes a presumption in favour of sustainable development¹⁵. For **plan-making** this means that:
- plans should positively seek opportunities to meet the development needs of their area, and be sufficiently flexible to adapt to rapid change;
 - strategic policies should, as a minimum, provide for objectively assessed needs for housing and other uses, as well as any needs that cannot be met within neighbouring areas, unless:
 - i. the application of policies in the Framework that protect areas or assets of particular importance provides a strong reason for restricting the overall scale, type or distribution of development in the plan area; or
 - ii. any adverse impacts of doing so would significantly and demonstrably outweigh the benefits, when assessed against the policies in this Framework taken as a whole.
- 4.4 The purpose of the Local Plan is to help deliver sustainable development¹⁶. It responds to the national growth agenda and is a step change in policy that will extend the scope and flexibility for new development that is needed in the National Park, or which would otherwise be beneficial to it.
- 4.5 In the context of the Northumberland National Park, development will be sustainable where it helps keep people living and working in the area with a good quality of life. In doing so, however, development should not erode the Special Qualities of the Park, which are its unique assets that lie at the heart of its reason for designation and duty to develop a stronger and more sustainable local economy in future.

¹⁴ NPPF paragraph 7 (MHCLG 2019)

¹⁵ NPPF paragraph 11 (MHCLG 2019)

¹⁶ The Local Plan is accompanied by and has been informed by a Sustainability Appraisal. This tests the Plan's objectives and policies against a series of sustainability objectives to ensure that it effectively contributes to the achievement of sustainable development.



Harthope © David Taylor, NNPA.

Climate Change

- 4.6 Climate change is one of the biggest challenges facing the environment, society and the economy both at a global and local level. Planning policies and decisions have an important role to play in taking a proactive approach to both mitigating and adapting to climate change. The UK Climate Change Act 2008 established a legally binding target for an 80% reduction in the UK's greenhouse gas emissions by 2050 and National Parks have an important role to play in meeting this challenge and responding to the effects of climate change. Local planning authorities are also bound by the legal duty in Section 19 of the 2004 Planning and Compulsory Purchase Act (as amended) to ensure that, taken as a whole, local plan policies contribute to the mitigation of, and adaptation to, climate change.
- 4.7 Climate change is at the heart of the strategic policies within this plan, specifically in the Sustainable Development criteria:

Climate change adaptation

Adjustments made to natural or human systems in response to the actual or anticipated impacts of climate change, to mitigate harm or exploit beneficial opportunities (NPPF glossary).

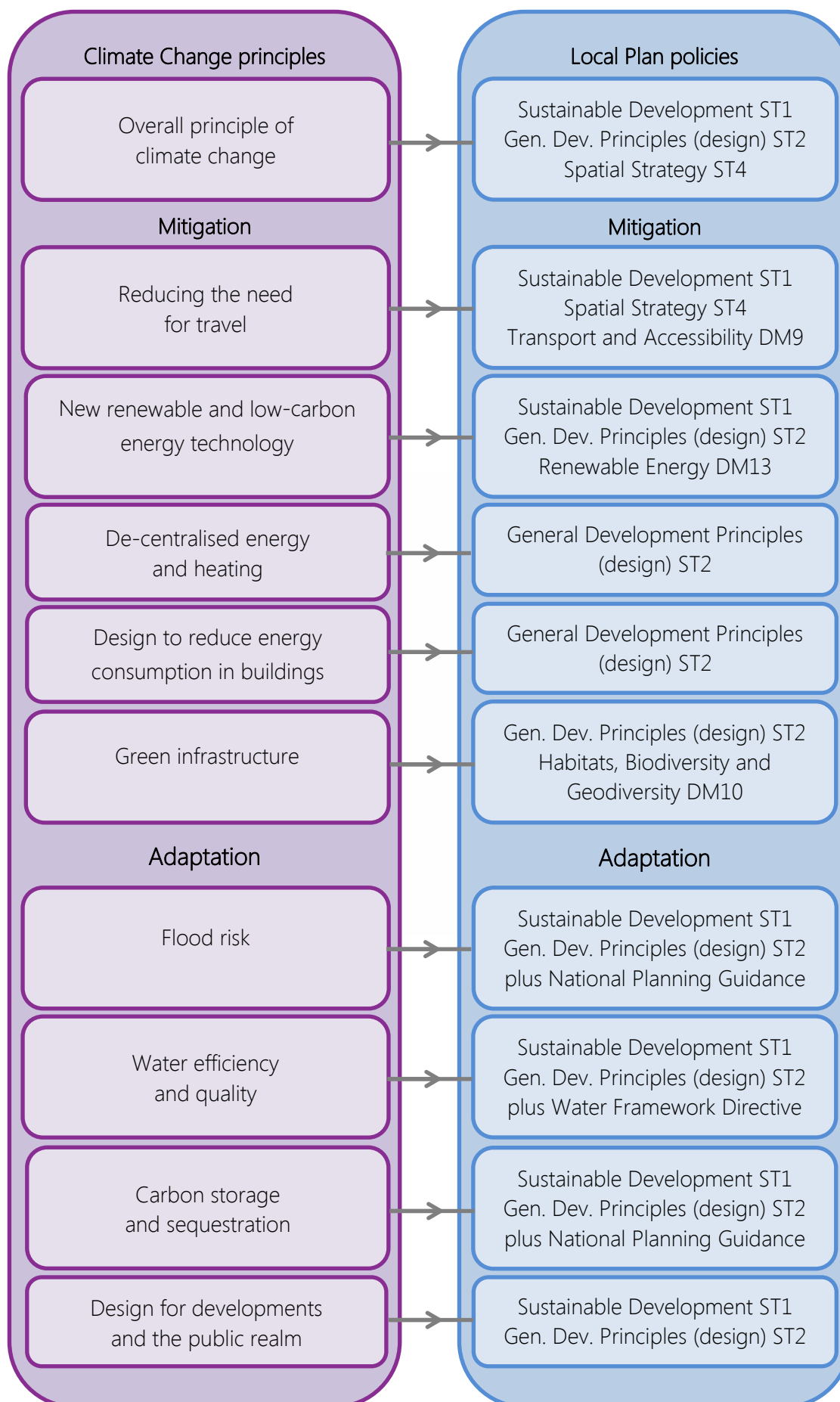
In the General Design principles we have sought to address:

Climate change mitigation

Action to reduce the impact of human activity on the climate system, primarily through reducing greenhouse gas emissions (NPPF glossary).

- 4.8 These strategic policies will be applied to all development and as such it is intended this will embed the importance of climate change consideration within all developments rather than as an add-on. The table below shows where climate change is a consideration in the Local Plan policies.

Table showing how Climate Change is integrated into the Local Plan



5. Strategic Policies

Sustainable Development

- 5.1.1 All public authorities, including Northumberland National Park Authority, have a biodiversity duty which requires them to, "*have regard, so far as is consistent with the proper exercise of those functions, to the purpose of conserving biodiversity*"¹⁷. The UK's commitment to the conservation of biodiversity is delivered through the Government's Biodiversity Strategy which sets an ambition to halt overall loss of England's biodiversity by 2020 and to move to a position of net biodiversity gain in the longer term, supporting a more integrated landscape-scale approach to conserve habitats on land and at sea, and improve links between them¹⁸.
- 5.1.2 This strategy will help nature to better withstand future environmental pressures such as climate change and provide a wider context for conservation work. The NPPF is clear that planning should contribute to conserving and enhancing the natural and local environment, improving biodiversity by minimising impacts, providing net gains for nature, protecting geological conservation, and contributing to the Government's commitment to halt the overall decline in biodiversity, including by establishing coherent ecological networks that are more resilient to current and future pressures. Biodiversity is also of value to the local economy, in terms of the important habitats and wildlife that are appreciated by people living in and visiting the area, but also in terms of the ecosystem services they provide.
- 5.1.3 31% (32,757 ha) of the area of the National Park is comprised of priority habitats¹⁹. These priority habitats are the most important areas for biodiversity. They are nationally and internationally scarce and are home to a huge variety of wild plants and animals. About one third (8,873 ha) of priority habitats are protected by SSSI designation but the remaining two thirds have no special protection. However in 2014, a further 21,777 ha of priority habitats were managed under Higher Level Stewardship agri-environment schemes leaving just over 2,000 ha without enhanced management practices²⁰. Despite this the National Park has experienced a decline in bird nesting²¹ and there is a need to halt and where possible reverse this.
- 5.1.4 Flood risk can arise from fluvial, surface water and tidal flooding. The Environment Agency is responsible for managing the risk of flooding from main rivers, large reservoirs, estuaries and the sea, and must be consulted on certain applications. The presence of formal raised manmade flood defences within the National Park is limited. Long term planning for flood risk within the National Park is set out in Catchment Flood Management Plans. These provide a catchment overview of the main sources of flood risk and how these can be managed in a sustainable way for the next 50 to 100 years. The policy options range from no active intervention, to taking further action to reduce flood risk. The National Planning Policy Framework advocates that inappropriate development in areas at risk of flooding should be avoided by directing development away from areas at highest risk or, where development is necessary, making it safe without increasing flood risk elsewhere.

¹⁷ HM Government (2006) Natural Environment and Rural Communities Act 2006 (Section 40).

¹⁸ DEFRA (2011) Biodiversity 2020 – A Strategy for England's Wildlife and Ecosystem Services.

¹⁹ NNP State of the Park Report (2018)

²⁰ NNP State of the Park Report (2015)

²¹ Natural England

- 5.1.5 National policy sets out a sequential test for assessing the flood risk of proposed development²². The sequential test is a simple decision-making tool designed to ensure that sites at little or no risk of flooding are developed in preference to areas at higher risk. Development should avoid areas of flood risk, and the presumption is that all development should be located within Flood Zone 1 (areas with the least risk of flooding). Where this is not possible, then sites within Flood Zone 2 can be considered (areas of low to medium risk). Only where there are no reasonably available sites in Flood Zones 1 or 2 should the suitability of sites in Flood Zone 3 (highest risk) be considered, taking into account the flood risk vulnerability of the type of development proposed²³. The National Park Authority will consult the Environment Agency on any large-scale proposals within flood risk areas. A sequential approach will be used in areas known to be at risk from any form of flooding. Other sources of flooding (not included in the flood zones), which require consideration, are surface and ground water flooding, and flooding from sewers and artificial sources. The National Park Authority will consult the lead local flood authority on proposals which raise surface water or other local flood risk issues where appropriate.
- 5.1.6 When considering development proposals the Authority will take a positive approach that reflects the presumption in favour of sustainable development contained in the National Planning Policy Framework. It will always work proactively with applicants and secure development that improves the economic, social and environmental conditions in the area.
- 5.1.7 Planning applications that accord with the policies in this Local Plan (and, where relevant, with policies in neighbourhood plans) will be regarded as sustainable development and approved without delay, unless material planning considerations indicate otherwise. When considering whether a development proposal is sustainable or not, account will be taken of the sustainable development goals set out in Strategic Policy ST1.
- 5.1.8 Where there are no policies relevant to the application or relevant policies are out of date at the time of making the decision, the Authority will grant permission unless material considerations indicate otherwise, taking into account whether:
- a) any adverse impacts of granting permission would significantly and demonstrably outweigh the benefits, when assessed against the policies in the National Planning Policy Framework taken as a whole; or
 - b) specific policies in that Framework indicate that development should be restricted.



Robin at Harbottle Crag © Will Nicholls, NWPA.

²² NPPF Paragraph 157 (MHCLG 2019).

²³ DCLG (2015) Planning Practice Guidance: Flood Zone and Flood Risk Tables, Table 2: Flood Risk Vulnerability Classification, Paragraph: 066 Reference ID: 7-066-20140306

Policy ST1: Sustainable Development

1. Northumberland National Park Authority will adopt a presumption in favour of sustainable development. Sustainable development in the Local Plan area is development that either achieves or does not prejudice the achievement of the following:
 - a) makes the National Park a high quality place to live and work – including: improving and supporting the use and retention of existing services, infrastructure and facilities (including the housing stock and workplaces);
 - b) reduces the need to travel and encourages sustainable modes of transport;
 - c) contributes positively to the built environment by having regard to the site context;
 - d) protects or enhances the landscape character²⁴ of the National Park through use of high quality design, appropriate landscaping, and removal of unsightly development;
 - e) improves biodiversity by protecting existing priority habitats and species or creates new priority habitat;
 - f) conserves the quality and quantity of natural resources, including water²⁵, air, soils and geodiversity;
 - g) makes efficient use of land and infrastructure, in particular by prioritising the use of previously developed land and buildings;
 - h) improves public access to, and enjoyment of, the National Park's special qualities²⁶;
 - i) reduces waste and greenhouse gas emissions through improved energy efficiency and making full use of small-scale renewable energy;
 - j) protects and enhances habitats that provide important carbon sinks, including peat habitats and woodlands;
 - k) development avoids increasing flood risk, and allows for the natural drainage of surface water;
 - l) conserves or enhances the historic environment and helps secure a sustainable future for the assets at risk; and,
 - m) furthers the statutory National Park purposes and duty.

²⁴ Landscape character assessment and NCA profiles

²⁵ by helping to protect or enhance Water Framework Directive (WFD) status.

²⁶ As set out in NNP Management Plan 2016-2021

General Development Principles

- 5.2.1 It is important that new development is to a high standard of design and quality, so that it can serve many generations to come. Most development has a visual impact but some forms of development also have a long-term impact on the intensity of use in an area, for example in terms of vehicle movements or use of services such as shops, waste collection or water supply. If new development is of a high quality it will add to the high quality of the National Park environment.
- 5.2.2 Design is a key aspect of sustainable development. It goes to the heart of most planning proposals. Attitudes to design, especially in an area with a strong vernacular built tradition, are shaped by what has gone before but will also need to adapt to suit changing technologies, materials, climate, building styles and expectations.
- 5.2.3 Northumberland National Park has a distinctive built heritage. The use of local stone and vernacular design with little architectural detail is characteristic of the area. This presents a challenge of managing change in a sympathetic way to ensure that new buildings respond to modern needs yet sit in harmony with the historic structures in the surrounding area. This needs to start with a clear appreciation of context, so that proposals can be designed to 'fit in', without slavishly reproducing designs from the past. With larger scale development it will require an understanding of how the site relates to the wider landscape.
- 5.2.4 The rural nature of the National Park clearly requires different solutions from an urban environment. National Park designation also brings with it a requirement for planning decisions to conserve and enhance the cultural heritage, wildlife and natural beauty of the area. The consequence is that development solutions will require greater sensitivity to their context. The National Park Authority nevertheless encourages innovation in architecture, materials and technology for new buildings but will normally require more traditional methods for changes to historic buildings.
- 5.2.5 To help designers and developers respond to these challenges the Authority is updating a Design Guide Supplementary Planning Document that provides advice about, and examples of, the quality expected. The Authority will use it to influence proposals and to negotiate on schemes during pre-application discussion and to support decisions on planning applications.

Energy Efficiency

- 5.2.6 Energy efficiency is an important aspect of sustainability and climate change mitigation. The Local Plan does not contain a policy that prescribes a set level of energy efficiency in new buildings, or that requires consequential improvements to existing buildings. This is because the national Building Regulations promote energy efficiency and are already seeking staged improvements towards a zero carbon standard for many new buildings. Also, flexibility is preferred over prescription; especially given the number of traditionally constructed buildings, where more bespoke energy efficiency measures may need to be considered. By the same token, a number of policies in the Plan seek to realise positive effects on statutory purposes, for example by securing the re-use of traditional buildings and opportunities for people to visit and stay in the National Park.
- 5.2.7 The majority of development proposals in the Park are modest in scale. The effects of and impact on climate change can be minimised through climate change adaptation and mitigation measures

incorporated into scheme design. The Authority encourages developers to engage with officers and seek pre-application advice at an early stage of the development process.

Policy ST2: General Development Principles

1. To maintain and enhance the distinctive character of the National Park, development will be permitted where:
 - a) The special qualities of the National Park will be conserved or enhanced;
 - b) The proposal is of a high quality design that will make a positive contribution to the National Park's special qualities and the local environment incorporating high quality construction materials and design details that reflect or complement the local vernacular;
 - c) The siting, orientation, layout, scale, height, massing and density of the proposal are compatible with existing buildings and the local built form;
 - d) The proposal is located in an area identified as being at the lowest risk of flooding unless it satisfies relevant sequential and exception tests and it can be demonstrated that the development will remain safe for users without increasing the risk of flooding elsewhere;
 - e) The proposal will not have an unacceptable adverse impact upon the amenities of adjoining occupiers;
 - f) Sustainable design and construction techniques are incorporated in the proposal including design features to ensure that they provide resilience to climate change, measures to minimise waste and energy use and where appropriate use energy from renewable sources;
 - g) Incorporate a good quality landscaping and planting scheme where appropriate, which reinforces local landscape character, increases habitat connectivity and makes use of appropriate native species;
 - h) Opportunities are taken to enhance local wildlife and biodiversity, including providing net gain, that are proportionate to the development proposed.
 - i) Opportunities are taken to incorporate multi-functional green infrastructure as an integral part of the scheme design and commensurate with the scale of the proposal;
 - j) The proposal ensures the proportionate creation of an accessible, safe and secure environment for all potential users with appropriate cycling facilities and car parking provision and without compromising highway safety, the local road network or public rights of way;
 - k) The proposal ensures the provision of appropriate and proportionate services and infrastructure to meet the needs of the development and that these are capable of being provided without compromising the quality of the landscape;
 - l) The proposal will be served by appropriate and adequate storage, waste management and other infrastructure proportionate to the scale of development proposed; and
 - m) The proposal will not give rise to unacceptable risks from contaminated or unstable land. If the proposal is located near to land known or suspected of being contaminated or unstable, an assessment shall accompany an application and shall include suitable remedial measures including timeframes for when such measures will be undertaken.

Major Development

- 5.3.1 It has been national planning policy since 1949 to try to avoid very large- scale development from taking place within national parks. The assumption is that there are less sensitive landscapes elsewhere or alternative solutions to the siting of major scale development in a National Park. Paragraph 172 of the NPPF requires major development to avoid National Park locations except in exceptional circumstances where it is in the clear public interest to do so.
- 5.3.2 Other than some post-war quarrying, forestry, military training operations and the recently opened Sill: National Landscape Discovery Centre the Northumberland National Park has largely avoided major development. This is partly because it is bypassed by the main communication and infrastructure corridors but also because it does not contain any large settlements.
- 5.3.3 National planning policy presumes against major new development in National Parks and Areas of Outstanding Natural Beauty because of the likely harm it would cause to the nation's long term interest of conserving these places. Major development is defined here as development of more than local significance, which will also have a long-term impact on the landscape, wildlife or cultural heritage of a National Park because of its scale and form. Examples from other National Parks include reservoirs, power stations, large housing estates, dual carriageways and high voltage overhead power lines.
- 5.3.4 The Otterburn Training Area (OTA) is the second largest military training area in the UK after Salisbury Plain and is used to provide live firing and other training facilities for the Ministry of Defence. The Training Area covers approximately 23,000 hectares, the majority of which is hill and moorland used for upland hill grazing. It is acknowledged that military operations at the OTA make a major contribution to the country's defence capability, and provide essential facilities which could not be easily replicated elsewhere.
- 5.3.5 Within Northumberland National Park, development is classed as major when its characteristics and specific impacts are likely to have a significant impact on the special qualities of the National Park. This scale of development could have a potentially significant impact on the special qualities of a National Park. Major development is only permitted inside National Parks in exceptional circumstances. Proposals are subject to the most rigorous examination and have to demonstrate that they are genuinely in the nation's interest if they are to proceed.
- 5.3.6 Major development in this instance is that set out in paragraph 172 of the NPPF which says '*for the purposes of paragraphs 172 and 173, whether a proposal is 'major development' is a matter for the decision maker, taking into account its nature, scale and setting, and whether it could have a significant adverse impact on the purposes for which the area has been designated or defined.*

Policy ST3: Major Development

1. Proposals for major development will only take place in exceptional circumstances and where it can be demonstrated that they are in the public interest. The applicant will be required to demonstrate:
 - a) The need for the development including a national need and the contribution of the development to the national economy;
 - b) The impact of permitting it, or refusing it, upon the local economy;
 - c) Whether, in terms of cost and scope the proposal cannot viably and technically be located elsewhere outside the National Park in a place that would avoid conflict with the National Park's statutory purposes; or that the need for it cannot be met in some other way;
 - d) The extent to which the proposal is designed and sited to respect the character of the landscape; and where appropriate, the settlement in which it lies; and
 - e) Whether all possible measures have been taken to minimise and mitigate any adverse effects on; the special qualities of the National Park, the ability for the public to understand and enjoy the special qualities; the setting of historic assets, natural resources and the transport network.
2. When the activity for which the major development is required ceases the land will be required to be suitably restored or enhanced where it is appropriate to do so.



The Sill: National Landscape Discovery Centre © NNPA.

Settlements

- 5.4.1 The purpose of the planning system is to contribute to the achievement of sustainable development that includes supporting strong, vibrant and healthy communities by providing the type of development that reflects the community's needs and supports its health, and social and cultural well-being²⁷. This Plan takes account of the different roles and character of areas and in promoting sustainable development in rural areas and locates development, such as housing, where it will enhance or maintain the vitality of rural communities. This includes recognising that in the National Park with its sparse population groups of smaller settlements may share and support services within and between their communities.
- 5.4.2 The settlement hierarchy will help to ensure that National Park settlements are socially cohesive and equitable by maintaining and creating balanced and mixed communities. Identifying settlements where new development is considered to be acceptable, provides opportunities for development to be in closer proximity to services and jobs and helps to maintain social networks. In the small dispersed communities within the National Park even a relatively low number of affordable homes can enhance their long term sustainability and have a positive outcome for those who live and work here. The spatial strategy therefore aims to address the local need for affordable housing, provide opportunities for the diversification of the National Park's economy and maintain a range of local services and facilities.
- 5.4.3 **Named Settlements:** The settlements named in Policy ST4 have a more 'self-contained' character with facilities serving the wider community. Some settlements may not have facilities at all and they may be 'shared' amongst groups of settlements. The Local Plan allows for small scale development in or adjoining these areas to meet local housing, employment and community needs, including 'principal residence' housing on infill sites. No development boundaries or limits are defined and the suitability of a site for development will be defined on a case-by-case basis.
- 5.4.4 **Open Countryside:** Outside of the Named Settlements, the rest of the National Park is classed as 'open countryside' where development will not be permitted, save in a very few circumstances. Open countryside is defined as areas with no development, sporadic development or isolated buildings. Whether a building is isolated will be determined on a case-by-case basis.
- 5.4.5 The best location for most development is in or on the edge of settlements that already have a range of services and infrastructure, and that are more likely to offer access to public transport. The objective is to improve the long-term viability of local communities by supporting existing services through new development whilst protecting open countryside from development that does not need to be located there. Development will be permitted outside settlements where it supports farms and rural enterprises that derive their primary inputs from the land or where it provides public infrastructure, or would otherwise comply with specific policies in the Local Plan.

²⁷ NPPF paragraph 7 (MHCLG 2019)

Policy ST4: Spatial Strategy

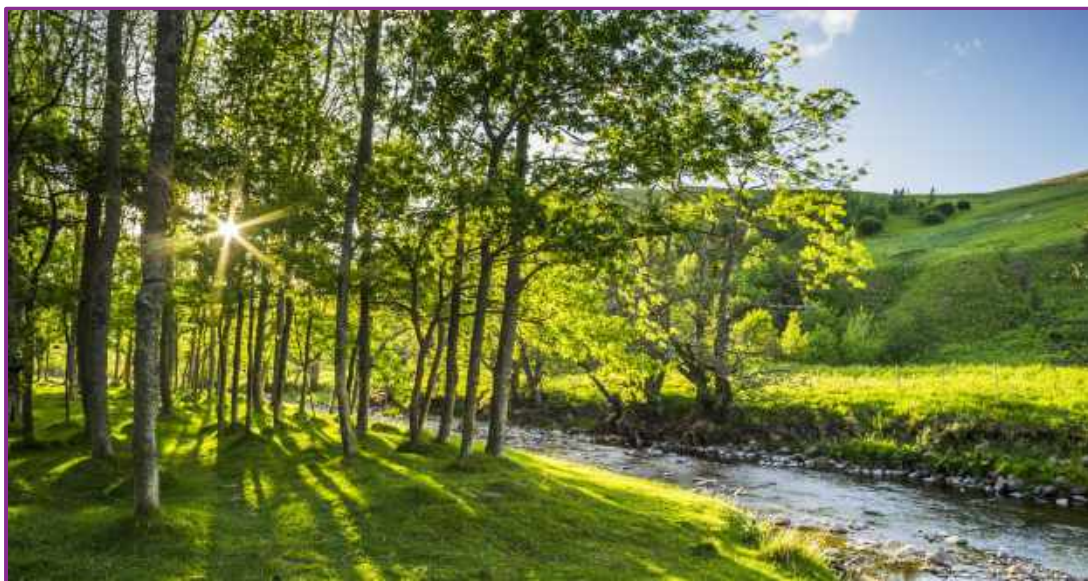
Named Settlements

Alwinton, Charlton, Elsdon, Falstone, Greenhaugh, Harbottle, Holystone, Ingram, Kirknewton, Lanehead, Rochester, Stannersburn and Stonehaugh.

1. Development should support the service function and sustainability of the Named Settlements by providing additional small scale housing (principal residence or affordable) and employment premises, new facilities and services (including tourism and recreation) that would be proportionate to the size of each settlement.

Open Countryside (including farmsteads and hamlets)

2. Development will only be permitted in Open Countryside in the following cases:
 - a) Where development reuses a building in a way that supports an economic use or meets the need for principal residence or affordable housing, and is also in accordance with Policy DM6;
 - b) Where there is an essential need for development to meet the needs of farming, forestry, tourism, recreation and other rural enterprise or land management activities;
 - c) Where it is essential to meet social or community needs and it can be demonstrated that there are no other suitable and available locations within the Named Settlements;
 - d) Where the proposal is supported by other relevant Local Plan policies.



Breamish valley © David Taylor, NNPA.

Housing

- 5.5.1 National planning policy protects National Parks from development that would be harmful to their Special Qualities. The National Park Circular states that these areas are not suitable locations for unrestricted housing, and that the focus should be upon providing for local housing need. The Local Plan is not, therefore, expected to release inappropriate amounts of land in response to all types of demand. Instead, it is expected to prioritise locally derived housing needs, by releasing a supply of sites that would support the social and economic needs of communities that live and work in the area²⁸.
- 5.5.2 The Special Qualities of Northumberland National Park make it a particularly desirable place to live, but its rural character and openness is vulnerable to new residential development. National planning policy strictly controls house building outside towns and villages for reasons of sustainability and to protect the character of the countryside. Paragraph 78 of the NPPF (2019) states that in order to promote sustainable development in rural areas, housing should be located where it will enhance or maintain the vitality of rural communities and that new isolated homes in the countryside should be avoided unless there are special circumstances.
- 5.5.3 The population of the National Park is ageing with the number of residents aged 65 or over being projected to increase by approximately 63% by 2037 (to 1,023 persons). This presents a major strategic challenge to provide appropriate housing and enable adequate adaptation of current stock to support these residents. Evidence²⁹ suggests that the key drivers in determining the tenure and type of future housing within the National Park are:
- The need to continue development to reflect the housing choices of residents, taking into account the changing demographic profile of Northumberland National Park;
 - Developing an increasing range of housing and support products for older people;
 - Delivering additional affordable housing to help offset the identified net shortfalls; and diversifying the range of affordable options by developing Intermediate tenure dwellings and products;
 - The economic viability of delivering affordable housing on sites across Northumberland National Park.
- 5.5.4 Northumberland National Park is an area with a high proportion of vacant homes (including second and holiday homes) which currently stands at 20% of existing housing stock and as such is an area (alongside rural parts of the rest of Northumberland County) where there is a need to provide a wider range of housing choice³⁰.
- 5.5.5 In relation to housing tenure approximately 58.4% of occupied properties are owner-occupied (35.0% owned outright and 23.4% owned with a mortgage), 35.3% are private rented or living rent-free and 6.2% are affordable (rented from a social landlord or shared ownership). In addition approximately 98% of dwellings within the National Park are houses or bungalows with 60% of these being detached, 24% being semi-detached, 14% terraced, 2.1% flats and 0.3% being caravan or mobile accommodation. Further, approximately 6.2% of all the 871 households in the National Park live in affordable housing mainly renting from a social housing landlord, with the

²⁸ DEFRA (2010) English National Parks and the Broads: UK Government Vision and Circular (paragraph 78).

²⁹ Northumberland National Park Strategic Housing Market Assessment (2017)

³⁰ Census 2011

Northumberland Housing register indicating that there are approximately 29 households in the National Park area that require affordable housing³¹.

- 5.5.6 In accordance with paragraph 11 of the NPPF strategic local plan policies should, as a minimum, provide for objectively assessed needs for housing and other uses, (as well as any unmet needs from within neighbouring areas) unless the application of other national policies that protect areas or assets of particular importance (such as designated landscapes) provide a strong reason for restricting the overall scale, type or distribution of development in the plan area.
- 5.5.7 The need (both affordable need and market demand) for housing in the Northumberland National Park has been objectively assessed. The 2017 Northumberland National Park Strategic Housing Market Assessment (SHMA) provides evidence to underpin planning for the delivery of housing in the area over the Plan period. The objectively assessed housing need (OAHN) for Northumberland National Park is for up to approximately 160 units over the plan period (2017-2037)³² with approximately 40 of these being affordable.
- 5.5.8 In terms of a housing requirement, the SHMA concluded that although low past completions would imply an upwards adjustment to the OAN, due to the physical and environmental constraints, the OAN of up to 8 dwellings per year would be acknowledged. Therefore, Northumberland National Park has a housing requirement of approximately 160 dwellings over the plan period (8 per year on average). This Plan will not allocate housing sites. Due to the very small requirement figure and reliance on windfalls, a housing trajectory was considered to have no practical purpose and has not been included in the plan.
- 5.5.9 The National Parks and the Broads Vision and Circular states that National Parks are not suitable locations for unrestricted housing and general housing targets are not provided³³. However, it is intended that the housing requirement will be met in full through a combination of small windfall sites, affordable housing (including on exception sites), the conversion of buildings to residential use, custom and self-build housing and the delivery of dwellings built within the gateway settlements of Wooler, Rothbury, Bellingham and Haltwhistle. This is in accordance with the joint Statement of Common ground agreed with Northumberland County Council under the Duty to Cooperate³⁴.
- 5.5.10 The National Park Authority will positively encourage the delivery of custom and self-build housing and be proactive in exploring ways to approve plots in pursuit of the duty set out in the Self-Build and Custom Housebuilding Regulations.
- 5.5.11 It is considered that this approach is appropriate in a remote rural area, given the small size of Northumberland National Park's settlements, landscape sensitivity/capacity, anticipated SHLAA supply and that it is consistent with National Park purposes, the duty to local communities and national policy and guidance.

³¹ Census 2011 & Northumberland National Park Strategic Housing Market Assessment (2017)

³² Northumberland National Park Strategic Housing Market Assessment (SHMA) (2017)

³³ DEFRA (2010) English National Parks and the Broads UK Government Vision and Circular, London: Department for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, para. 78.

³⁴ NNPA/NCC Joint Statement of Common Ground (September 2019)

Principal Residence Housing

- 5.5.12 Overall vacancy rates (i.e. the difference between dwellings and households) is approximately 20% across the National Park area (taking into account second homes and holiday homes). The comparative statistic for Northumberland is 6.4% and just over 4% for the North East and England³⁵. Policy intervention is required in order to address this issue.
- 5.5.13 Principal Residence housing is a form of market housing controlled by a mechanism which ensures it can be lived in by anyone but only as their principal residence. The aim of this mechanism is to prevent any new market housing being used as a second or holiday home and reduce any potentially harmful impact on the social well-being of a number of communities where the overall proportion may be significantly higher than 20%.
- 5.5.14 Where permission is granted for a Principal Residence market dwelling, a condition will be attached to ensure that the occupancy of the dwelling(s) is confined to a person's sole or principal residence in perpetuity.

Replacement Dwellings

- 5.5.15 In the open countryside national policy and guidance is restrictive towards the development of new housing as is the approach set out in strategic policy ST4. There will be occasions however where it is necessary to replace an existing unsuitable dwelling with a new one. This can provide an opportunity to enhance the landscape through better design and use of materials, as well as delivering a much more energy efficient and comfortable modern home.
- 5.5.16 Assuming the building still has a lawful residential use, the main planning consideration will be whether repair is possible or not and whether replacement is capable of securing any beneficial improvement in terms of appearance and landscape impact.
- 5.5.17 Replacement dwellings should not be substantially larger than the original. The reason for this is to mitigate landscape impact and avoid a precedent that might undermine the Authority's housing strategy which seeks to maintain a range of house sizes and types across the National Park. Permitted development rights will be removed at the time of permission and further extensions that would increase the size of the dwelling will need to be considered on a case-by-case basis.
- 5.5.18 Replacement dwellings will not have their occupancy restricted by legal agreement, unless the original dwelling was already restricted in this way.
- 5.5.19 Applications for replacement dwellings often come forward where an existing dwelling is in disrepair. Listed buildings or dwellings that are considered to be of historic or architectural importance will not be considered for replacement without a thorough justification³⁶. The Northumberland National Park Historic Environment Record includes information on the historic built environment and can provide useful evidence for applicants proposing to replace an existing dwelling. Where the residential use has been abandoned, any proposals will be assessed against policies for new build residential dwellings.

³⁵ Census data (2011) and Northumberland National Park Strategic Housing Market Assessment (2017)

³⁶ In accordance with paragraph 194-197 of the NPPF (MHCLG, 2019)

Policy ST5: New Housing

1. Having regard to the existing housing stock in the locality, all new residential development (of more than 5 dwellings) will contribute towards the creation of sustainable, balanced and inclusive communities by ensuring a mix of dwellings (in terms of size, type and tenure), that will meet the needs of present and future generations.
2. Development proposals will be assessed according to how well they meet the needs of those living in and seeking to move to Northumberland National Park, as identified in the most recent Strategic Housing Market Assessment and other relevant guidance.
3. New housing will be permitted:
 - a. Within Named Settlements where it comprises conversion of an existing building or a small infill development providing principal residence or affordable housing.
 - b. In Open Countryside, providing Principal Residence occupancy;
 - i. where there is an essential need for a new dwelling to support established farming, forestry or other land management activities; or
 - ii. Where the development would represent the optimal viable use of a heritage asset or would be appropriate enabling development to secure the future of heritage assets; or
 - iii. the development would re-use redundant or disused buildings and enhance its immediate setting; or
 - iv. the development would involve the subdivision of an existing residential dwelling; or
 - v. the design is of exceptional quality; or
 - vi. where an existing dwelling needs to be replaced; or
 - vii. where a building is being converted in accordance with Policy DM6.
 - c. The replacement of an existing dwelling in the open countryside will only be permitted where:
 - i. Residential use has not been abandoned;
 - ii. The dwelling is not of architectural or historic importance;
 - iii. If the replacement dwelling is not in the same position as the existing building, provision shall be made for the removal of the redundant building in a timely manner where it is appropriate to do so.
4. Self-build and custom housebuilding may be approved in accordance with other relevant housing policies, and as either:
 - a) affordable housing; or
 - b) principal residency.
5. Affordable housing will be permitted in accordance with Policy DM3.

6. Development Management Policies

Community Facilities and Infrastructure

Community Facilities

- 6.1.1 Community facilities are important for maintaining the social fabric and well-being of the National Park's communities. They include buildings and spaces that provide places to congregate and socialise (village halls, pubs), learn and develop (schools, nurseries), worship (churches, chapels), and businesses and public facilities that provide for the basic day-to-day needs of communities (post offices). Broadband and mobile phone services in the National Park are generally very poor so, in support of wider social and economic goals and in conjunction with funding schemes from national government, it is vital that this infrastructure is improved.
- 6.1.2 The National Park has experienced a loss of community facilities. In such a rural area, they often rely on public subsidy, voluntary effort but perhaps above all, adequate use. There is a risk that short to medium term changes in circumstance, whether the withdrawal of a grant for a local sports facility or a reduction in the number of children attending a primary school, could result in the loss of a community facility. The planning system needs to guard against this. By the same token, as community needs change and evolve, there is a need for the planning system to keep pace, supporting new or improved facilities as and when they are required.

Infrastructure

- 6.1.3 Infrastructure provision will be key to the delivery of sustainable development, including economic growth and meeting the development needs of the National Park. As such, the Authority will support new infrastructure that addresses current shortfalls or enhances provision, subject to its associated impacts being acceptable.
- 6.1.4 The 2017 NNPA Infrastructure Plan recognises infrastructure as a wide-ranging term comprising the physical network of services and facilities that are required for an area to function properly. Infrastructure is considered to include, but is not limited to, the following:
- Public transport and roads;
 - Flood defences;
 - Schools and other education/childcare provision;
 - GP surgeries and other healthcare facilities;
 - Community meeting places and facilities (including public houses);
 - Social care facilities;
 - Energy supply and distribution;
 - Telecommunications,
 - Water and wastewater supply/disposal;
 - Key retail outlets;
 - Emergency services;
 - Sports and recreational facilities;
 - Cultural institutions like libraries and museums;
 - Waste processing and disposal facilities.

- 6.1.5 The remoteness and terrain of the National Park imposes limitations and costs on infrastructure, which mean deficiencies, continue to exist. These are usually to the detriment of local communities and business. Although there needs to be an element of realism in the level of infrastructure that can be achieved, improvements are still potentially realisable in some of the most basic services.
- 6.1.6 Improving broadband and mobile telecommunications services is an important objective in the National Park Management Plan. Such services are now an integral part of modern lifestyles and business operations, and an essential pre-requisite for attracting the sort of business with the scope for sustainable growth in the National Park. They are also vital in remote rural areas to provide on-line access to services that are otherwise physically located many miles away. Better broadband and mobile services will not only benefit residents and businesses but also the millions of people who visit the National Park each year. The policy facilitates this expansion of broadband and mobile infrastructure for the benefit of all, whilst at the same time minimising any environmental impacts.
- 6.1.7 Due to the very modest scale and volume of development in the National Park, it is not feasible for the Authority to charge developers via the Community Infrastructure Levy (CIL). It is generally expected that most development will not give rise to the need for additional infrastructure, but it is, however, possible that for some larger, unplanned developments or developments where infrastructure is at or near capacity, it will be necessary for the applicant to secure necessary improvements to infrastructure before development can proceed. This will depend on the location of the development and the type of infrastructure required. For example, for some infrastructure there are legal duties to accommodate additional demand where as for others, such as surface water drainage, it is necessary to explore more tailored solutions.
- 6.1.8 It is important to ensure that any new development is only permitted if the infrastructure required to service it has adequate capacity. Where additional or enhanced infrastructure is necessary directly as a result of the proposed development, the applicant should be expected to provide a financial contribution equivalent to the cost of remedying the infrastructure shortfall. This contribution would be secured through a legal agreement under Section 106 of the Town & Country Planning Act.
- 6.1.9 The risks of this type of reactive, case-by-case approach to infrastructure planning are recognised and even though the Authority will not be charging a Community Infrastructure Levy on new development, it will liaise with infrastructure providers to assess capacity issues. This will assist in anticipating where developments, individually or cumulatively, might give rise to the need for improvements. If any serious or recurrent infrastructure shortfalls become apparent, the Authority's approach to the Community Infrastructure Levy in the National Park will be reviewed.
- 6.1.10 Existing infrastructure will inevitably need to be replaced or upgraded over time. The Authority recognises that it is essential for meeting the day-to-day needs of communities, so will respond positively to any proposals while ensuring that they represent the optimal solution for communities and conserve or enhance the special qualities of the National Park.
- 6.1.11 Supporting the development of new infrastructure will increase the quality of life for those living, working or visiting the National Park, whilst protecting the area's special qualities.

Policy DM1: Community Facilities and Infrastructure

Community Facilities

1. Proposals that would result in the loss of or an unacceptable adverse impact on a community facility will not be permitted, unless it can be demonstrated that the facility is no longer suitable or viable in that location or that it is no longer needed.
2. Applications for the loss of community facilities must be supported by appropriate and proportionate independent evidence, including appropriate financial, business planning, options appraisals, marketing and community engagement evidence.
3. The provision of new community facilities will be permitted:
 - a) Within one of the Named Settlements;
 - b) In other locations, as an exception to Policy ST4, where it can be clearly demonstrated that there are no suitable sites in a Named Settlement and that this would be in accordance with other relevant local plan policies.
4. Improvements to existing, community facilities, will be supported where it would be in accordance with other relevant local plan policies.

Infrastructure

5. Proposals that would result in the loss of infrastructure will not be permitted, unless it can be demonstrated that the infrastructure is no longer suitable or required.
6. Proposals for new, improved or supporting infrastructure will be permitted where:
 - a) They represent the least harmful option reasonably available having regard to any operational requirements and technical limitations that are applicable;
 - b) The design minimises impact on visual amenity, including the character and appearance of the locality and the wider landscape;
 - c) There are no unacceptable adverse impacts on the National Park's special qualities;
 - d) They will not have a harmful impact on the wider environment particularly in relation to flood risk.
7. When no longer required for its approved purpose all infrastructure shall be removed and the site suitably restored to its former condition where it is appropriate to do so.

Housing and the Rural Economy

Housing Provision

- 6.2.1 The housing stock as a whole should provide a range of accommodation sizes, types and tenures to meet the needs of all sections of the local community. The National Park's existing housing stock has a higher than average proportion of larger and detached dwellings³⁷.
- 6.2.2 Evidence indicates a clear need for housing to meet the needs of elderly residents³⁸ it also acknowledges that the ageing population may increase demand for residential care facilities. However, a number of facilities are located within the gateway settlements and that this, coupled with the relatively low levels of overall population growth anticipated in the National Park would perhaps suggest that this could be accommodated within existing facilities, or through an expansion of home care services³⁹. This makes it unlikely that any extra care accommodation would be needed or provided within the National Park.
- 6.2.3 The development of additional housing both within and on the edge of the National Park has also been identified as being essential in supporting the growth of the tourism sector through the attraction and retention of a larger workforce with stakeholders also noting the need for greater flexibility for housebuilding within the Park to enable retiring/new agricultural workers to remain within the local area and to enable the re-use of derelict agricultural buildings for residential or commercial use⁴⁰.
- 6.2.4 This plan necessarily focuses on new development - which is a small part of the National Park's existing housing stock. Policy ST5, aims to ensure, in terms of size, type and tenure that new housing permitted in the National Park will result in a better mix of dwellings and that it contributes to that which is needed locally by giving those in housing need, including young people, the opportunity to stay in their community and contribute to the viability of important services such as schools.
- 6.2.5 The fundamental objective under these housing policies is to ensure that new dwellings remain more affordable to meet the community's needs in perpetuity. Where there is evidence of need for custom/self-build housing and/or accessible and adaptable housing, the National Park Authority, in discussion with the relevant housing authority, will seek to ensure that it is provided for through proposals, either as part of the affordable local needs housing itself (including custom/self-build plots) or where it is proven to be required to deliver the affordable housing as Principal Residence housing.
- 6.2.6 There is also growing interest in the potential for community land trusts to initiate community-led or other affordable housing schemes and this approach may be able to achieve mixed schemes with, for example, rented affordable housing, potentially managed by Registered Providers, local need custom/self-build housing and/or housing for first time buyers to address the range of needs

³⁷ NNP Strategic Housing Market Assessment (2017) and Housing Needs Survey (2016)

³⁸ NNP Strategic Housing Market Assessment (2017)

³⁹ NNP Economic Futures and Employment Demand Study (2018)

⁴⁰ NNP Economic Futures and Employment Demand Study (2018)

within a community. Opportunities to bring forward this type of housing will be explored with housing delivery partners such as the County Council and Communities CAN.

Householder Development

- 6.2.7 The role of the Householder Development policy is to provide reasonable flexibility for dwellings to be updated and extended whilst ensuring that the impacts of extensions are acceptable and to retain a mix of dwelling sizes that will help to sustain balanced communities across the National Park. The overall size and design of extensions should be proportionate to ensure that the character of the surrounding landscape, individual buildings and settlements are conserved or enhanced. The National Park Authority will require that extensions are sympathetically designed and proportionate in scale, bulk and form to the original dwelling.
- 6.2.8 Extensions for dwellings that are subject to a local occupancy tie to ensure they meet the local community's need for affordable (or more affordable housing) will be very carefully considered. The need for an extension will be considered taking account of Nationally Described Space Standards and the effect on the affordability of the dwelling in the longer term. This is because such homes have been permitted to provide an opportunity for local people to own their own home, who would otherwise be unable to afford to buy a home on the open market. Together with the local need occupancy tie, the size of these dwellings ensures that they remain more affordable for local people in perpetuity.

DM2: Householder Development

1. Proposals for development within the domestic curtilage of a dwelling should take full account of the character of the local area and the special qualities of the National Park and will be permitted where:
 - a) The scale, height, form, position and design of the new development do not detract from the character and form of the original dwelling or its setting in the landscape;
 - b) The development does not unacceptably affect the residential amenity of neighbouring occupiers or result in inadequate levels of amenity for the existing dwelling;
 - c) Any extension should be subservient to the main building.
2. An extension to an affordable home that is subject to a local occupancy tie will only be permitted if it would not make the dwelling unaffordable for current or future occupants.
3. In the case of existing outbuildings and the development of new outbuildings, the following criteria must also be met:
 - a) The outbuilding should be required for purposes incidental to the residential use of the main dwelling;
 - b) Any new or extended outbuilding should be proportionate in size;
 - c) New outbuildings should be appropriately sited in relation to the existing built development on site.

Affordable Housing

- 6.3.1 In delivering affordable homes, housing providers have to consider a variety and range of needs for different sizes, types and tenure of home (such as those for local workers, accessible and adaptable housing, housing for those with care needs, and single people or young families). This is an important part of assessing need and housing providers and developers will need to show that they have taken into account the housing needs of the local community. Single properties will tend to be from private developers or self-builders aiming to satisfy a particular individual (though proven) need. Following a rural exceptions site approach, the need for the mix of dwellings and the viability of a proposal, will be assessed on a case-by-case basis. Any market (Principal Residence) housing will also need to reflect the needs of the area for sizes and types of homes to help create a more balanced housing stock.
- 6.3.2 The SHMA⁴¹ indicates that there is a clear need for affordable housing in the National Park. Analysis of affordable housing requirements evidenced an overall imbalance (shortfall) of 40 affordable dwellings over the Plan Period 2017-2037 and an imbalance (shortfall) of 2 dwellings each year, with most of this need (61.8%) for 1 and 2 bedroom dwellings and 38.2% for 3 or more bedroom dwellings. However, this is not a target for delivery; rather it expresses the overall need from the Housing Register compared with the current supply of affordable housing.
- 6.3.3 There are a low number of brownfield sites suitable for new housing within the National Park. If the few remaining suitable housing sites and traditional buildings within settlements are not used to provide local needs housing, then it will put pressure on other sites outside settlements that have the potential to harm the landscape. The approach of providing housing to meet local needs through the Local Plan has to be based upon the 'exceptions' approach - to grant planning permission where general open market housing would not be permitted. Sites will not be allocated, because of the need to maintain land at 'rural exceptions site' values in order to maximise delivery of local needs affordable housing. Instead they will be released on evidence case-by-case basis subject to evidence of need.
- 6.3.4 Applying the 'exceptions' approach - that local need affordable housing may be permitted, where new housing would not normally be allowed - has the effect of reducing the value of land and buildings to a more reasonable level so that local communities and housing providers can acquire sites and buildings for affordable housing. Within the terms of the local needs housing policies, affordability is judged on a household-by-household basis. Those in need of affordable housing will be households who cannot afford to rent or buy a home on the open market.

⁴¹ NNP Strategic Housing Market Assessment (2017)

Policy DM3: Affordable Housing

1. In order to meet specifically identified local affordable housing needs, the development of 100% affordable dwellings will be permitted as, an exception to policy, on appropriate sites adjoining a Named Settlement, provided a Sustainability Appraisal demonstrates that the homes will contribute to the environmental, social and economic sustainability of the settlement where appropriate.
2. Proposals on exceptions sites will only be permitted where:
 - a) The need for the proposed number, type, size and tenure of affordable dwellings is supported by an up-to-date local housing needs assessment and the proposed rent and/or mortgage costs are affordable for local people;
 - b) The number, design, materials and proposed layout of the dwellings are appropriate to the size, form and character of the settlement;
 - c) There is no conflict with the NNP Landscape Character Assessment and the proposal is supported by an up-to-date visual impact assessment;
 - d) Robust arrangements are put in place to ensure that the dwellings remain affordable to the community in perpetuity;
 - e) Effective community engagement has been undertaken.
3. Within a Named Settlement (where the site is capable of accommodating more than five dwellings) 50% of dwellings provided will be affordable.
4. Where a scheme is proposed within a Named Settlement and there are exceptional circumstances which demonstrate that the delivery of the required proportion of affordable housing would not be financially viable, the Authority will consider a larger proportion of principal residence housing as part of a proposal.
5. On sites within a Named Settlement where between 6 and 10 dwellings would be provided, the Authority will accept the payment of a commuted sum in lieu of the on-site delivery of the relevant proportion of affordable housing required provided that it is demonstrated that on-site delivery (including any element of principal residence housing) would not be viable.
6. The occupancy of all affordable dwellings will be restricted to those in need of affordable housing who also have a local connection in accordance with the criteria set out in this Local Plan.

Local Connection Criteria

- Currently resident in the National Park (or in another part of a parish split by the National Park boundary), having been resident there for at least the previous 3 years;
- Currently in employment in the National Park; or
- Having an essential need to live close to relative(s) who are currently living in the National Park (or in another part of a parish split by the National Park boundary), have resided there for at least the previous 3 years and require substantial support; or
- Having an essential requirement for substantial support from relatives who are currently living in the National Park (or in another part of a parish split by the National Park boundary) and have resided there for at least the previous 3 years.



Caw Gap, Hadrian's Wall © David Taylor, NNPA.

Rural Workers' Housing

- 6.4.1 New houses for rural based enterprises should normally be located within or adjacent to the farmstead or other existing group of buildings, and should not be located in isolated locations.
- 6.4.2 Approval of new agricultural dwellings can lead to the sale of existing farm houses and create further pressure for additional housing. Conditions will, therefore, be attached that restrict the occupancy of existing houses on the same agricultural unit, unless there are material mitigating circumstances that can be demonstrated. Such conditions will not be permitted to be relaxed in response to subsequent changes in the circumstances of the occupier of the farm, unless it can be demonstrated that the current and anticipated future need for agricultural workers' dwellings in the locality are otherwise adequately met. Other types of rural enterprise dwellings permitted under this Policy will also be subject to precise occupancy restrictions through planning conditions or legal agreement.
- 6.4.3 The size of the new dwelling should be justified in relation to the reasonable operational needs of the enterprise. The objective is to provide for the needs of rural enterprises including future as well as initial occupiers.
- 6.4.4 National policy states that housing should be located where it will enhance or maintain the vitality of rural communities and that new isolated homes in the countryside should be avoided⁴². Policies in this Plan therefore focus new build housing in the settlements named in Policy ST4 'Settlement Hierarchy'. Housing for rural workers in agriculture and forestry who have an essential need to live permanently at or near their place of work can sometimes justify a new home in open countryside. Nevertheless, a rural enterprise must be acceptable in its location before a new home is even considered and it will often be more sustainable for workers to live in nearby towns or villages or in suitable existing housing.
- 6.4.5 Justifying a new home outside of a named settlement, in the open countryside depends on the essential functional and financially sound needs of an enterprise for full-time employees to live at their place of work. Normally, this will be full-time agricultural workers, as forestry employment based upon contract labour is often less spatially fixed.
- 6.4.6 Dwellings for rural workers in the open countryside, whether through a conversion or for a new build dwelling, will therefore require the submission of an independently prepared appraisal to accompany an application. This will need to justify an essential functional need for a rural worker and the long-term financial viability of the business, with a requirement that the worker(s) needs to be readily available at most times, day and night for most of the year, and bearing in mind current and future business requirements.
- 6.4.7 Evidence should be submitted to demonstrate that:
- a) there is a clearly established *existing* functional need for the new dwelling;
 - b) the need relates to a full-time worker or one who is primarily employed in farming, forestry or other essential land management activities and does not relate to a part-time requirement;

⁴² In accordance with paragraph 79 of the NPPF (MHCLG, 2019).

- c) the unit and the agricultural activity concerned have been established for at least three years, have been profitable for at least one of them, are currently financially sound, and have a clear prospect of remaining so;
- d) the functional need could not be fulfilled by another dwelling on the unit, or any other existing accommodation in the area which is suitable and available for occupation by the workers concerned; and
- e) Other planning requirements, for example in relation to access, siting and impact on the landscape, are satisfied.

6.4.8 A *functional test* must be met. This means that it must be demonstrated that it is essential for the proper functioning of the enterprise (or activity) for one or more workers to be readily available at most times. Such a requirement might arise, for example, if workers are needed to be on hand day and night:

- a) in case animals or agricultural processes require essential care at short notice;
- b) to deal quickly with emergencies that could otherwise cause serious loss of crops or products, for example, by frost damage or the failure of automatic systems.

6.4.9 The protection of livestock from theft or injury by intruders may contribute on animal welfare grounds to the need for an agricultural dwelling, although it will not by itself be sufficient to justify one. Requirements arising from food processing, as opposed to agriculture, cannot be used to justify an agricultural dwelling. Nor can agricultural needs justify the provision of new dwellings as retirement homes for farmers.

6.4.10 A *financial test* must be met. This is to make sure that the farming enterprise is economically viable and to provide evidence of the size of dwelling which the unit can sustain. Agricultural dwellings should be of a size commensurate with the established functional requirement. Dwellings that are unusually large in relation to the agricultural needs of the unit, or unusually expensive to construct in relation to the income it can sustain in the long-term, will not normally be permitted. It is the requirements of the enterprise rather than of the owner or occupier which are relevant to determining the size of dwelling that is appropriate to a particular holding.



Sheep in Upper Coquetdale © David Taylor, NNPA.

Policy DM4: Rural Workers' Housing

1. Proposals for new dwellings for workers engaged in farming, forestry or other essential land management activities will be permitted where the accommodation is essential to support a new or existing enterprise or activity, whether on a newly created or an established unit. In all cases it must be demonstrated that:
 - a) There is a clearly established existing functional need for a specialist full-time worker or one who is primarily employed in agriculture to live on the landholding, and that labour requirement does not relate to part-time employment;
 - b) The agricultural business is financially sound and viable with a clear prospect of remaining so, the activity and landholding units concerned having been established for at least three years and been profitable for at least one of those last three years;
 - c) The functional need could not be fulfilled by any existing dwelling on the landholding unit or any other existing accommodation in the immediate area, which is suitable (including by means of refurbishment or appropriate extension) and potentially available for occupation by the workers concerned;
 - d) The proposed location is well related to existing buildings; and
 - e) The proposal would comply with other relevant local plan policies.
2. Any application to remove an existing agricultural or rural workers' occupancy condition will only be permitted where it can be demonstrated that there is no longer a need for the accommodation on the holding or from persons meeting the conditions in the locality. Where this has been successfully demonstrated the condition will be substituted with a condition limiting the dwelling to principal residence housing in accordance with Policy ST5.



Black House, Catcleugh © Paul Buxton, NNPA.

Housing for Gypsies, Roma, Travellers and Travelling Showpeople

- 6.5.1 The accommodation requirements of travelling communities, who include gypsies, travellers and travelling show people, are part of the overall accommodation needs to be addressed across a local planning area and considered alongside the housing needs of settled communities. National planning policy requires local planning authorities to identify sites for Gypsy and Traveller pitches where there is evidence of need. If there is no evidence of need then authorities are required to set out an exceptions policy, similar to that applied to affordable housing. The purpose is to provide criteria that will guide development, should a need become apparent during the Plan period. National planning policy also highlights the importance of ensuring that traveller sites are sustainable, recognises that some areas may have special or strict planning constraints and that local planning authorities have a duty to co-operate on planning issues that cross administrative boundaries.
- 6.5.2 An assessment of need for Gypsy and Traveller pitches has been carried out at County level and has not been disaggregated to the National Park boundary⁴³. Nonetheless, levels of need are negligible and so the evidence is insufficient to justify allocation of a site within the National Park.

DM5: Accommodation for Gypsies, Roma, Travellers and Travelling Showpeople

1. Proposals for permanent sites within the National Park to meet the identified accommodation needs of Gypsies, Roma, Travellers and Travelling Showpeople will only be permitted if it can be demonstrated that:
 - a) There is a proven permanent need as evidenced by a Gypsy, Roma, Traveller and Travelling Showpeople Accommodation Assessment;
 - b) It can be demonstrated that National Park purposes will not be compromised;
 - c) The proposed site is in close proximity to the highway network in a position that is appropriate to the locality with existing screening;
 - d) Essential infrastructure and services can be provided at the site without there being a harmful impact on the surrounding area;
 - e) The site is reasonably accessible to local services, including schools and has sufficient space for vehicle parking and manoeuvring.

⁴³ Northumberland Gypsy, Traveller and Travelling Show people Accommodation Assessment (2015)

Conversion and Enhancement of Buildings

- 6.6.1 Buildings form an important part of the architectural and historic fabric of the National Park, and reveal much about its social, cultural and economic history. Changing circumstances mean many buildings have outlived their original purpose. It is important that the planning system facilitates change of use where this helps to conserve the interest of these buildings. Care is however needed to ensure new uses and their impacts do not undermine what makes these buildings valuable, and that they are permitted in locations that have capacity for the new use.

Policy DM6: Conversion of Buildings

1. Proposals for the conversion of buildings within the settlements identified by Policy ST4 will be permitted.
2. Proposals for conversion of buildings in Open Countryside will be permitted where:
 - a) The building makes a positive contribution to the landscape and special qualities of the National Park;
 - b) The building is structurally sound and capable of conversion without substantial rebuilding, as demonstrated by a suitably qualified structural engineer's report;
 - c) The building is of sufficient size to accommodate the proposed use without the need for significant alterations, extensions or other new buildings;
 - d) The proposal is of high quality design which retains existing features which contribute significantly to the character of the building or its setting;
 - e) The proposed use does not lead to changes in the building's curtilage or the creation of any new vehicular access or parking area that would unacceptably affect the character and appearance of the building or the surrounding landscape;
 - f) The requirements of Policy DM14 are also met.
3. The proposed new use must be compatible in nature, scale and level of activity with the surrounding locality and any neighbouring buildings. Acceptable new uses for rural buildings that may be permitted under this policy are:
 - a) Employment, education or training use;
 - b) Holiday accommodation or tourism facilities
 - c) Principal residence housing, provided that:
 - i. The building is located within an existing group of buildings that have a close physical and visual relationship to each other and also include an existing residential unit within that group;
 - ii. the building is redundant or disused and the conversion would enhance its immediate setting; and
 - iii. it is not in an isolated location.
 - d) Purposes incidental to the residential use of the dwelling, where the building is within the immediate curtilage of an existing dwelling.

Rural Economy and Diversification

- 6.7.1 The latest Census data suggest that the Northumberland National Park has a small 'working age' population of less than 1,600 people. However, the local rate of economic activity (76%) is significantly higher than the National Park and England averages of 70%. This is due to a relatively high number of full-time and particularly self-employed workers, while part-time employment is relatively low meaning that rates of economic inactivity are therefore lower than average. The gateway settlements surrounding the National Park (including Bellingham, Otterburn, Rothbury, Haltwhistle, Hexham and Wooler) are also an important source of labour and services for businesses and residents within the Park. However, connectivity between these areas is considered to be poor, with no regular public transport options generating a reliance on car travel.
- 6.7.2 Farming (and forestry) is the dominant industry within the National Park being the primary economic sector employing residents (22%) and accounts for two thirds of businesses and 55% of jobs located within the National Park. The percentage of residents employed in farming and forestry has also declined from 28% in 2001 to 22% in 2011. The economically active population has increased from 74% in 2001 to 76% despite an increase in the number of retired people. This is due to the relatively high numbers of full-time and particularly self-employed workers whilst the number of people looking after the home/family, long-term sick/disabled, and students has declined (consistent with a decline in the younger population)⁴⁴.
- 6.7.3 An analysis of the sectoral breakdown of employment within the National Park identifies that the largest sectors within the local economy are: agriculture, forestry and fishing; manufacturing; accommodation and food services; and administrative and support services. Manufacturing and administrative and support services are two of the only sectors within the National Park to experience jobs growth between 2006 and 2016. Agriculture, forestry and fishing and accommodation and food services, however, both declined and underperformed relative to national and regional trends⁴⁵.
- 6.7.4 The evidence also shows that the National Park's business base is dominated by micro firms and small businesses. ONS data indicates that there are no businesses operating within the National Park that employ more than 50 members of staff (with 97% employing fewer than 10). It also highlights connectivity as a key challenge for the local economy at present. Road connectivity and public transport access is relatively poor, with a number of local businesses viewing this as a cause of recruitment difficulties. In addition, business satisfaction in relation to broadband provision is understood to be low, with this impacting upon recruitment and networking activities. It does, however, note that work is currently underway to improve broadband provision across the National Park.
- 6.7.5 More than three quarters of the National Park is farmed at present, with more than 256 farms located within, or partly within the Park boundary. A more detailed understanding of the size and nature of agricultural holdings can be obtained via an analysis of data published by DEFRA in 2017. This indicates that there were that there were 256 farm holdings in 2009 (including 178 commercial holdings). The total number of holdings remained broadly static from 2007 to 2009 whilst the number of commercial holdings has subsequently increased to 180 in 2016⁴⁶. Farms

⁴⁴ Northumberland National Park State of the Park Report (2015)

⁴⁵ NNP Economic Futures and Employment Demand Study (2018)

⁴⁶ NNP Economic Futures and Employment Demand Study (2018)

within the National Park are typically larger than the national average for hill farms, albeit the size does vary considerably across the study area (reflecting differences in terrain). The average farm in the Cheviots, for instance, is four times larger than the average Hadrian's Wall farm.

- 6.7.6 Without a viable local economy that supports people and communities to live and thrive, the landscape and its associated qualities would eventually degrade through lack of conservation and management. The public would then not be able to enjoy the National Park to the same extent and the wider benefits it brings to the nation and to society would be eroded. The health of the local economy is, therefore, of key importance to the future of the National Park. The recent opening of the Sill: National Landscape Discovery Centre and its associated rural enterprise hubs has provided a boost to the economy of the National Park and wider region to the tune of approximately £5 million per year in additional visitor spending.
- 6.7.7 The established brand and quality of Northumberland National Park presents business opportunities that are wider than just tourism and farming. Certain types of business thrive in designated landscapes that have strong rural identities and high perceived qualities of life. There is a direct link between protected landscapes and business success⁴⁷. The promotion of national parks and their special qualities tend to be an asset to business rather than a constraint. National parks attract home workers and footloose micro enterprises. Consequently the local plan explores how to best support sustainable land-based rural enterprises.
- 6.7.8 The Authority is not planning to meet a specified employment land requirement. It is extremely difficult to plan in this way for such a rural area, particularly given the predominance of micro-business and home based working. Instead, this Plan pursues an opportunity-based approach, facilitating development as and when the need for them arises.
- 6.7.9 Evidence⁴⁸ suggests that the National Park performs better than the County, regional and national average in terms of its economic activity, economic inactivity and employment rates; however indicators suggest the existence of limited capacity to increase the local workforce from the existing population. This represents a potential growth constraint for sectors with a high labour replacement need, or an ageing workforce.
- 6.7.10 The National Park also benefits from relatively low levels of deprivation (as defined by the levels of income, employment, education, health, crime, barriers to housing and services and living environment), with the majority of the Park falling within the 50% least deprived in England. Pockets within the north of the NNP, however, including the settlements of Shotton, Westnewton, Hethpool, Kirknewton, Akled, Langleeford, Greensidehill and Ingram are ranked within the 30% most deprived areas in England⁴⁹.
- 6.7.11 With regards to business premises, evidence shows that most premises in the National Park are small reflecting occupier requirements which will often derived from indigenous businesses wanting workspace without having to relocate. Premises are typically old but maintenance and refurbishment have prolonged their economic life. New premises are principally tourism related. Overall requirements have been largely accommodated within the existing building stock. In addition an analysis of travel-to-work patterns demonstrates that the strongest linkages are with Northumberland and, in particular, the settlements of Rothbury, Bellingham, Hexham and Alnwick.

⁴⁷ Valuing England's National Parks April 2013

⁴⁸ NNP Economic Futures and Employment Demand Study (May 2018)

⁴⁹ NNP Economic Futures and Employment Demand Study (May 2018)

This is also supported by the travel-to-work catchments defined by ONS, which show the majority of the NNP as being located within the wider Hexham, Blyth and Ashington areas⁵⁰.

- 6.7.12 Focussing on commercial holdings (defined by DEFRA as those with significant levels of farming activity), on the basis that more up-to-date figures are available; this shows that the amount of rented farmland fell by 2% (from 51,013ha to 50,046ha) between 2009 and 2016. In contrast, the level of owned farmland increased by 53% over the same period (from 21,028ha to 32,221ha)⁵¹. This continued shift towards owned farms could have potential consequences for agricultural land-use within the NNP in that the personal and business objectives of individuals will shape decisions regarding tenure.
- 6.7.13 There is a small concentration of land ownership in the NNP, with 50% of the farmland owned by large landowners (Forestry Commission, Northumberland Estates, Ministry of Defence, Lilburn Estates and College Valley Estates). As a consequence, any change of policy by one of the few large landowners will significantly affect the data.

Home-based Businesses

- 6.7.14 Working from home reduces commuting and supports local services. Planning permission is not normally needed to convert a room to a home office or craft workshop, as long as the use remains subordinate to the main use as a dwelling. Where planning permission is required for an extension, an ancillary building or an intensification of the employment use, then the Authority will be supportive, subject to safeguarding neighbouring residential amenity and mitigating any other harmful impacts. Where the employment use would grow to a level of activity that would exceed the capacity of a residential area, road network or environment to contain it, then the Authority will encourage relocation to a more appropriate employment site.
- 6.7.15 The development of new bespoke buildings for shared residential/business use is a potential opportunity that could fit well into the National Park context. It could be used to promote the National Park as a place to live and work by solving the problem of having to find two separate properties at the same time. It could attract new, low-impact, high-quality and skilled jobs, develop stronger business networks and entrepreneurship, support construction of new local occupancy housing, support existing services and reduce carbon emissions from commuting and modern energy-saving technologies. There is a wide range of low impact uses that would be compatible in the deeply rural context of the National Park. These would include workshops, light manufacturing, food processing, professional services, packaging, journalism, music production, internet sales etc.
- 6.7.16 Census data and evidence shows that 60% of the 1,032 residents who live and work in the National Park do so from home⁵². This is largely because of the predominance of agriculture and small tourism providers. More recently home internet connections have enabled people in other business sectors to work at least some of their time from home. This form of employment offers potential scope for sustainable growth, if high-speed broadband can reliably reach more areas of the National Park.

⁵⁰ NNP Economic Futures and Employment Demand Study (May 2018)

⁵¹ NNP economic Futures and Employment Demand Study (2018)

⁵² Census 2011

Farm Diversification

- 6.7.17 Farm diversification is another way to grow and improve the resilience of the rural economy. Diversification encompasses activities to enhance the quality and value of farm produce, promote local food, deliver ecosystem services, light manufacturing and contracting that support traditional farming or shooting estates. There are particular opportunities for visitor accommodation, visitor services, nature tourism and recreational activities that make use of the Special Qualities of the area. This policy, therefore, supports and encourages well-conceived diversification schemes that will increase spending, create jobs, improve economic resilience, deliver services and help manage land in accordance with National Park purposes.
- 6.7.18 The Authority supports proposals to diversify farm and estate businesses. Diversification can extend to almost any new business proposition as long as it is appropriate in scale and impact to its rural context and remains subordinate to the primary land-based enterprise. Development may involve conversion of traditional buildings and re-use of modern agricultural sheds or the construction of a new building or structure. The Authority also supports farm and estate diversification because of its inherent economic benefits and because it can support farming and land management activity, which conserves and enhances landscape quality.

Leisure and Tourism

- 6.7.19 The tourism industry plays a significant part in the Northumberland National Park (NNP) economy, with 9% of the employed population working in accommodation and food services and a further 4% working in recreation. In terms of premises, the 2017 Rating List indicates that there are 114 hotels/guest houses/self-catering accommodation units within the NNP, representing an increase of 54 since 2011. This increase is largely due to additional holiday accommodation, particularly self-catering and guest houses. However, this rate of increase (73%) is lower than the 118% increase experienced outside of the Park, potentially due to change of use restrictions outside the NNP and the availability of premises within the NNP's boundaries. The number of camping and caravan sites within the NNP has also declined over this period, falling from 20 in 1990 to 13 in 2017 (-35%). Supporting activities including outdoor pursuit centres/retreats have declined from 4 to 3 between 1990 and 2017, although cafes and restaurants have increased from 1 to 5 over the same time period. These facilities now represent an important part of the visitor offer, helping to extend visitor duration and spend⁵³.
- 6.7.20 Sports facilities form an important element of the tourism offer within the NNP including cycle routes; walking routes; horse-riding; grouse shooting and fishing. Whilst these facilities do not typically require physical buildings and there are no studies suggesting an undersupply, consultees noted that there are no cycle hire facilities/cycle hubs available within the NNP, unlike the nearby Kielder Water⁵⁴. Other leisure facilities do not relate directly to the special qualities of the National Park but are nevertheless an important part of the wider visitor experience of it. It is essential that these facilities are as good as they can reasonably be within the proviso that they do not themselves, prejudice National Park purposes.

⁵³ NNP Economic Futures and Employment Demand Study (2018)

⁵⁴ NNP Economic Futures and Employment Demand Study (2018)

- 6.7.21 The National Park is designated because of the value of its landscapes, tranquillity, dark skies, wildlife and cultural heritage and the opportunities they offer for the public to visit and enjoy them. Successive visitor surveys confirm that it is the scenery, open spaces, opportunities for walking and tranquillity that are the main reasons why people visit the National Park. These special qualities, however, need to be supported by infrastructure such as car parking, footpaths, trails, access areas, toilets, shops, cafes, pubs and interpretive material to accommodate visitors and facilitate their enjoyment of the area. These facilities need to be maintained and sometimes improved and extended and that will often require planning permission.
- 6.7.22 In terms of wider recreational facilities available for residents of the NNP, the 2017 Infrastructure Plan identifies no formal public leisure centres, with built facilities comprising village halls or educational related facilities. Evidence indicates that the majority of residents are happy with the current level of accessible open space. Therefore based upon the current surplus of provision in the north and west of the County, as well as the aspiration to maintain a level of provision equivalent to 1.69 hectares per 1,000, it is anticipated that the modest level population growth projected within the National Park is unlikely to generate a need for the provision of further outdoor sports facilities over the Plan period⁵⁵.
- 6.7.23 This policy is intended to complement existing forms of visitor accommodation and open up opportunities for existing operators, farmers and rural estates to diversify into new markets. The objective is to diversify supply and support more year round visitor stays, provide opportunities for multi-day visitor activities and educational packages, and generate more spending in the local economy.



Cattle on a farm in the Cheviots © David Taylor, NNPA.

⁵⁵ NNP Economic Futures and Employment Demand Study (2018)

Policy DM7: Rural Economy and Diversification

1. Development that contributes to the economic and social well-being of local communities within the National Park will be permitted where one or more of the following criteria are met:
 - a) It promotes and protects existing businesses by providing flexibility for established rural businesses to diversify and expand;
 - b) It provides opportunities for the operation of home-based businesses where appropriate;
 - c) It helps maintain or increase job opportunities in the agricultural and forestry sectors;
 - d) It provides for and supports small and micro businesses through the provision of small, flexible, start-up businesses or incubator uses;
 - e) It provides additional facilities, or better use of existing facilities, including those which provide further opportunities to understand and enjoy the special qualities of the National Park.
2. Proposals for new sustainable rural economic development (including the diversification of existing agricultural or forestry businesses) will be permitted where:
 - a) The scheme is well designed and will make use of an existing building and complies with other relevant plan policies. New buildings will only be permitted if the diversified use cannot be suitably accommodated through the conversion or alteration of an existing building in accordance with Policy DM6;
 - b) The proposed use is compatible with and subsidiary to an existing farming or forestry activity in terms of physical scale, activity and function;
 - c) The proposal is of a quality, scale and design that takes into account and reflects the sensitivity of the local landscape;
 - d) Existing access arrangements are appropriate for the proposed use and the site can be safely accessed by the existing road network;
 - e) There are satisfactory arrangements for storage, parking and the manoeuvring of vehicles.
3. Small-scale diversification proposals will be supported where they demonstrate sustainable practices and outcomes sustain the long term operation of the business and secure multiple wider public and environmental benefits.
4. Proposals for tourism and recreational development will be permitted where:
 - a) They conserve and enhance the natural beauty, wildlife, tranquillity and cultural heritage of the National Park;
 - b) They provide and protect opportunities for people to increase their awareness, understanding and enjoyment of the special qualities of the National Park in a manner that will not undermine the enjoyment of those qualities by other visitors or the quality of life of residents;
 - c) They are of a quality, scale and design that takes into account and reflects the sensitivity of the local landscape;
 - d) They do not lead to unacceptable harm in terms of noise and activity (including traffic).
5. In the case of new buildings for tourism and recreation uses development will be permitted where:
 - a) It is located within one of the settlements listed in Policy ST4;
 - b) It uses existing buildings in open countryside or involves the adaptation or small scale extension of an existing building;
 - c) It is within the open countryside but in accordance with Policy ST4.

Agricultural Development

- 6.8.1 The National Park Management Plan recognises that the landscape is shaped by farming and land management practices and it contains a number of objectives to support these industries and to improve the value of their produce and their environmental outputs.
- 6.8.2 Most agricultural operations are either not classed as development or are permitted without the need for formal planning permission. However, above certain thresholds, some farm buildings and structures do require consent because of their size and potential environmental impact. The role for planning policy in the National Park is to help farmers and land managers find the best locations, designs, materials and solutions to meet their operational requirements but with the least harmful impact on the special qualities of the area. This is usually successful and most farm businesses are able to develop a range of buildings and structures to undertake their modern operational requirements.

Policy DM8: Agricultural Development

1. Proposals for new agricultural buildings and structures or extensions to existing buildings will be permitted where:
 - a) The form, height and size of the proposed development is appropriate to its setting and will not have an adverse impact on the landscape and special qualities of the National Park;
 - b) There is a functional need for the building to sustain existing primary agricultural activity and the scale of the development is commensurate with that need;
 - c) The building is designed for the purposes of agriculture and uses appropriate materials with subdued colours and non-reflective surfaces;
 - d) The site is related physically and functionally to existing buildings associated with the business unless there is an exceptional agricultural need for a more isolated location;
 - e) The proposal will not significantly harm local amenity in terms of noise, odours or level of activity either individually or in combination with the existing agricultural activity;
 - f) Where appropriate, a landscaping scheme is provided which complements the character of the locality and retains existing and/or introduces new planting to reduce the visual impact of the proposal on the wider landscape and encourages biodiversity.
2. The Authority may impose a condition on appropriate planning permissions requiring the removal of the building or structure if it is no longer needed for agricultural purposes.

Transport and Access

- 6.9.1 The NPPF highlights that the Local Plan should support a range of transport modes with priority given to walking, cycling and public transport and consideration of disabled access. Accessibility to essential services is difficult for those who do not have access to a private car, or regular public transport services.
- 6.9.2 Transport policies have an important role in facilitating sustainable development and minimising greenhouse gas emissions. Sustainable modes of transport are supported, however it is recognised that the rural nature of much of the National Park, and its dispersed population, means that the majority of people rely on the private car to access jobs, services and facilities⁵⁶. The settlement strategy set out in Policy ST4 (Spatial Strategy) recognises that new development should be focused in the named settlements to help maintain their future sustainability, self-sufficiency and resilience, and should not lead to a severe increase in traffic.
- 6.9.3 The National Park Authority consults with the Highway Authority (Northumberland County Council) on all developments where access and transport is a relevant planning consideration. Where planning for car parking to serve residential development, it is recognised that car ownership varies most directly in relation to dwelling size. This is reflected in the parking standards for residential development which require variable provision based on the number of bedrooms in the dwelling. The Authority will refer to the parking standards in the Northumberland County Council Local Plan Appendix which sets out the level of off-street car parking in new development. As with Northumberland County Council standards, in relation to non-residential development, the standards are not expressed as either a maximum or a minimum. Instead, they provide an indication of the appropriate level of parking for different uses. With regard to residential development, parking requirements are expressed as the minimum level that would normally be required. Cycle parking will be required at new and extended Community Facilities, Leisure facilities, visitor facilities and tourist accommodation.
- 6.9.4 Well designed and safe access routes encourage walking. Northumberland National Park has an extensive public rights of way network along with more informal routes. This network provides access for walking, cycling and horse riding. Cycling infrastructure includes cycle routes which are not public rights of way. The Authority (in partnership with the County Council) will look to protect and enhance the coverage, standards and safety of these networks in accordance with the County Council's Rights of Way Improvement Plan.

⁵⁶ NPPF paragraph 84 (MHCLG 2019)

Policy DM9: Transport and Accessibility

1. In order to maximise accessibility and minimise the environmental and health impacts of traffic when assessing planning applications the National Park Authority will seek to:
 - a) Protect and where appropriate enhance existing networks of Public Rights of Way, National Trails, open access land and other access routes for use by pedestrians, cyclists and equestrians;
 - b) Encourage the creation of new access routes particularly when they create links between existing routes and local services;
 - c) Encourage small scale developments and facilities that contribute to the safe use of the right of way network;
 - d) Minimise the overall need for journeys, whilst seeking to maximise the proportion of journeys made by: public transport, bicycle, and walking;
 - e) Ensure that appropriate transport and accessibility needs are incorporated into new development proposals including the provision of car and cycle parking and supporting infrastructure;
 - f) Promote good design principles in respect of inclusive access; and
 - g) Where appropriate support the delivery of reliable, safe and efficient transport networks, in partnership with other organisations, service providers and developers.
2. New transport or access routes should take account of existing ecological networks and green corridors and where appropriate include measures to facilitate the safe movement of species across open spaces.



The road to Ewartly Shank © David Taylor, NNPA.

Natural Environment

- 6.10.1 The National Park designation provides the highest status of protection relating to conserving landscape and scenic beauty⁵⁷. The *National Planning Policy Framework* (NPPF) draws upon the requirements of legislation and other government policy that underpins this conservation and enhancement of the environment. Paragraph 172 of the NPPF sets out that:
- great weight be given to conserving landscape and scenic beauty in National Parks, and
 - the conservation of wildlife and cultural heritage are important considerations in these areas.
- 6.10.2 In addition, the NPPF makes it clear that the planning system should contribute to and enhance the natural environment through the protection and enhancement of valued landscapes, geological conservation interests and soils, minimising the impacts on biodiversity and, where possible, providing net gains in biodiversity. It also recognises the wider benefits of 'ecosystem services' (para. 170b), such as linkages between habitats, carbon storage, flood protection, water purification, and areas for recreation and enjoyment.
- 6.10.3 The location of Northumberland National Park in the northern upland of England puts it at an important ecological crossroads between other rich habitats. The historic low level of development and the extensive green spaces between its settlements, however, mean that there is a lot less pressure on these networks in the National Park than in more urbanised areas or intensively-farmed land elsewhere. It is unlikely that ecological networks will be a constraint to most types of new development in the National Park but they may present opportunities to shape development in ways that could enhance their functionality.
- 6.10.4 Northumberland National Park boasts a wide range of species and habitats, for example curlew, red squirrel, upland rivers and burns, ancient woodland, upland hay meadows, blanket bog and heather moorland. Extensive areas of the National Park have been designated for their international importance for nature conservation such as Special Areas of Conservation and Ramsar sites.
- 6.10.5 Within the National Park five of the Sites of Special Scientific Interest were designated for their geological importance, from the Cheviot volcanic and glacial features in the north to the Whin Sill intrusion and escarpments in the south. The Northumberland National Park Natural Environment Vision (2014) outlines our vision for the natural environment of Northumberland National Park up to 2035. It describes how the landscape, habitat and natural environment should change in response to appropriate human interaction and sustainable environmental and land management, both within and outside the National Park.
- 6.10.6 The role of the Local Plan and the planning system is to protect designated sites and species from developments that would be harmful and to mitigate the impact of development on other more locally-important habitats such as woodland, individual trees, roadside verges and geomorphological features. The Local Plan policies map identifies the areas of greatest habitat sensitivity, internationally and nationally important habitats.
- 6.10.7 This Local Plan presents a potential opportunity to make small and proportionate biodiversity gains on an application-by-application basis; a strategy that is encouraged by national planning policy. This would require certain types of new development to include proportionate enhancement

⁵⁷ Including Section 3 land.

measures. To ensure that these measures would be affordable, their cost should be minimal in relation to the overall value of a scheme.

- 6.10.8 Development costs in the National Park are already competitive because the Authority does not charge an infrastructure levy on planning permissions. There is, therefore potential financial scope for small scale biodiversity enhancement measures to be included in relevant planning proposals. This policy only applies to developments that have some form of biodiversity impact e.g. new buildings, housing, extensions, development of land and provision of infrastructure.
- 6.10.9 The National Park Authority will work with adjoining authorities, local communities and land managers, the private sector and conservation organisations to identify and take forward opportunities for biodiversity enhancement where this is consistent with landscape character.
- 6.10.10 The hierarchy of international, national and local wildlife sites will be shown on the Policies Map. Priority Habitats will not be shown on the Policies Map, and many of these will be protected by existing designations; however, applicants can seek advice from officers if it is considered that proposals may impact on priority habitats. In considering applications affecting the natural environment, the National Park Authority will seek to minimise impacts on biodiversity and provide net gains in biodiversity, where possible.

DM10: Habitats, Biodiversity and Geodiversity

1. The conservation and enhancement of wildlife, habitats and sites of geological interest within Northumberland National Park will be given great weight.
2. All developments and activities should:
 - a) Maintain and where appropriate enhance features of ecological value and recognised geodiversity assets;
 - b) Maximise opportunities to strengthen the integrity and resilience of habitats and species within the National Park and provide a net gain in biodiversity where possible; including those priority species for which the National Park supports a significant proportion of the regional or national populations and those found at the edge of their range; and
 - c) Maintain and where appropriate enhance existing wildlife connections and landscape features such as water courses, disused railway lines, hedgerows and tree lines for biodiversity.
3. Development proposals that are likely to have a harmful impact on protected or valuable sites or species will only be permitted where it can be demonstrated that:
 - a) There are no alternative options that would avoid or reduce the harm to the protected or valuable interest;
 - b) Suitable mitigation measures to avoid or reduce the harm have been incorporated into the proposals and will be maintained in order to retain their biodiversity or geodiversity benefits;
 - c) Any residual harmful impacts have been offset through appropriate habitat enhancement, restoration or creation on site or in another appropriate location within the National Park;

- d) The wider sustainability benefits of the development outweigh the harm to the protected or valuable interest.

4. Proposals will be considered in accordance with the following hierarchy:

International Sites and Protected Species:

- a) Proposals that have a likely significant effect on European sites (comprising Special Areas of Conservation, Special Protection Areas and Ramsar sites) will be subject to an appropriate assessment in accordance with the Habitats Regulations. Where the assessment indicates that it is not possible to ascertain that the proposal, either on its own or in combination with other plans or projects, would have no adverse effect on the integrity of the site, development will only be permitted in exceptional circumstances where there are no alternative solutions, there is an imperative over-riding public interest and compensation measures are secured. This protection will be extended to proposed or potential European sites and significant weight will be given to this policy in areas where the presence of internationally important features is recognised but no formal designation process has begun. Species protected under international legislation will also receive this highest level of protection.

National Sites and Protected Species:

- b) Proposals that would adversely affect the notified special interest features of an existing or proposed Site of Special Scientific Interest, National Nature Reserve or nationally protected species will only be permitted where it has been demonstrated that all opportunities to reduce harm have been included within scheme design. Any residual harm must be mitigated through an appropriate strategy. Where mitigation is not possible, compensation may be acceptable in exceptional circumstances.

Regional and Local Sites and other valuable habitats and species:

- c) Proposals that would adversely affect any existing or proposed locally designated site such as a Local Nature Reserve, Local Wildlife Site, Regionally Important Geological or Geomorphological Site or other valuable habitat or species will only be permitted where the benefits of the development clearly outweigh the impact on the protected interest.

5. Where a proposed development would attract a significant number of additional visitors to an area or facility, it should be demonstrated how any potential impact upon the area or feature of biodiversity interest will be managed as part of the new development.

Landscape, Tranquillity and Dark Skies

Landscape

- 6.11.1 The distinctive landscape character of Northumberland National Park is one of its special qualities. The importance of giving protection to the area's remote and inspiring landscape was fundamental to its designation as a National Park. Northumberland National Park is a living, working landscape that sits atop an underlying geology that was laid down some 400 million years ago. This has subsequently been shaped by glacial activity, water erosion, climatic weathering and more recent human land management activity. The upland land masses can generally be divided into the three distinct areas comprising the Cheviots, Simonside Hills and the cuesta ridges of Hadrian's Wall country that includes the Whin Sill. Dividing these masses are the watersheds of the North Tyne, Rede and Coquet, with smaller water bodies such as the River Breamish, Harthope and College burns radiating outwards from Cheviot itself, at 815 metres the highest point in the north east.
- 6.11.2 Human activity has had an increasing influence on the landscape character of the National Park, initially by altering the type and extent of vegetation that blanketed the underlying geology. The wildwood that established after the last ice age 10,000 years ago was gradually felled and replaced with swathes of grassland, moorland and wetland bog. Today we see a predominantly rural landscape with the upland moors giving way to semi-improved grassland on the valley sides and improved in-bye land around the farmsteads that tend to nestle in the valley floors. Upland hill farming predominates with 80% of the land managed in this way. The remaining 20% is largely set aside to commercial plantation forestry with Kielder Forest Park adjoining much of the western boundary of the National Park.
- 6.11.3 With this land management came the settlers and the onset of the built environment that has had a more dramatic influence on the landscape character, stretching back as far as the Mesolithic period (c 8,000 – 4,000 BC) through to today. From the early settlements and hill forts, Roman roads and camps, medieval villages, castles, bastles through to the modern road network, quarries, settlements, plantation forestry and overhead electrical and telecommunications infrastructure, development has increasingly had a greater influence on the landscape character of the National Park that we see today.
- 6.11.4 From Hadrian's Wall World Heritage Site in the south, to the prehistoric landscapes of the Cheviot Hills in the north, there are evocative reminders of our colourful past which survives largely undamaged by more recent agricultural or industrial activity. The many layers of historical landscapes in the National Park offer a rich opportunity for further understanding, appreciation and enjoyment; for example, there are 424 Scheduled Monuments, 228 Listed Buildings and over 4000 entries in the National Park's Historic Environment Record. The landscape of the Park has been shaped by farming and other rural land-based enterprises. Agriculture, forestry and fishing remain the primary business sectors, forming 47% of the National Park's total employment base⁵⁸.
- 6.11.5 One aspect of grouse moor and forestry management that has the potential to have a significant effect upon the landscape character and views of the National Park relates to the construction of formal forest roads and moorland tracks. From a landscape perspective, the key aspect to consider is whether both the construction and ongoing use of the track will leave the track surface in a

⁵⁸ NNP Economic Futures and Employment Demand Study (May 2018)

condition that it becomes visually prominent within the landscape. The expected means to mitigate against this would be to establish a sustainable re-vegetated surface. It is widely accepted that the sustainability of this type of track surface will be dependent upon a number of factors including, gradient of the track, the type of vehicle, frequency of use, weather conditions at the time of use and effectiveness of track maintenance being undertaken.

- 6.11.6 To maintain many of the Special Qualities of the National Park it is important that beneficial types of farming and land management continue. Many large modern agricultural buildings have been permitted where they are necessary for agricultural purposes. In order to enhance the landscape of the Park it is generally desirable that these buildings (and other development such as wind turbines, communications masts MOD infrastructure) should be dismantled when no longer required. Over time, new uses can sometimes outgrow a rural location.

Tranquillity and Dark Skies

- 6.11.7 Tranquillity is one of the special qualities of the National Park that is valued by people and any potential impacts on tranquillity from proposed development⁵⁹, need to be minimised to a level which would not adversely affect people's enjoyment of the National Park.
- 6.11.8 Northumberland National Park remains the most tranquil place in England and is the most tranquil protected landscape in England. The county of Northumberland is the most tranquil local authority area in England followed by Cumbria, North Yorkshire, and County Durham. Tranquillity scores for place areas within the National Park and Kielder Water and Forest Park were designated a 'Gold Tier' International Dark Sky Park in 2013, making it the largest dark sky protected area in Europe and the best place in England to view the night sky. The 2011 Resident Survey reveals that 83% of residents think that 'peace and tranquillity' make the National Park a special place. The relative importance of landscape and tranquillity to people visiting the National Park increased in 2014 with special qualities other than landscape / tranquillity such as cultural heritage, historic buildings, wildlife, and opportunities for outdoor recreation all tending to be cited less in 2014 than in 2011⁶⁰. Development proposals should have regard to the Northumberland National Park Good Practice Guide for Outside Lighting in Northumberland International Dark Sky Park (2017) and also the Northumberland International Dark Sky Park Lighting Management Plan (November 2015).



Night sky in Harbottle © Ian Glendinning, NNPA.

⁵⁹ Including sequential visual effects and cumulative landscape effects.

⁶⁰ State of the Park Report (2015)

Policy DM11: Landscape, Tranquillity and Dark Skies

1. The natural beauty and heritage of the National Park will be conserved and enhanced whilst being responsive to landscape change. All proposals will be assessed in terms of their impact on landscape character, views and sensitivity as defined in the Landscape Supplementary Planning Document. Development which would adversely affect the quality and character of the landscape will not be permitted.
2. Development proposals which conserve or enhance the tranquillity and pristine dark skies of the National Park will be supported. In order to limit potentially adverse effects on open countryside landscapes and to conserve or enhance tranquillity, development proposals will be required to demonstrate that:
 - a) The level of noise, traffic and light generated as a result of the development during construction and thereafter is minimised and dark night skies maintained;
 - b) Intrusive external features, such as hard surfaces, car parking and urban-style boundary treatments are minimised;
 - c) The sense of openness is not reduced;
 - d) The quiet enjoyment of the landscape is maintained.
3. New, extended or altered moorland tracks and forest roads can have a significant impact upon the appearance of the landscape, archaeology and on the biodiversity of an area. All track development should be well designed, and sensitive to its location. As such all applications for new tracks shall be submitted with details of and nature of the use, frequency of use, construction methodology, materials to be used in any hardsurfacing, water drainage features and an ongoing track maintenance plan.
4. All development proposals should avoid external lighting where possible. Where external lighting is necessary its design should avoid all unacceptable adverse impacts, or as a last resort mitigate them to the greatest possible extent in order to avoid unacceptable adverse impacts on tranquillity, dark skies, biodiversity, visual amenity, landscape character and heritage significance.
5. Development will be permitted where it can be demonstrated that it is compatible with the conservation and enhancement of Northumberland National Park's landscapes by ensuring that:
 - a) the visual impact of the development in its immediate and wider setting is minimised through high quality design that reflects local landscape character with particular regard to scale, siting, materials, and colour; and
 - b) the cumulative and/or sequential landscape and visual effects of development do not detract from the natural beauty of the National Park and the experience of tranquillity.
6. Proposals which are considered to be significant in terms of scale and/or impact should provide a professional landscape appraisal as part of the application submission.

Trees, Woodlands, and Forests

- 6.12.1 Trees, woods and forests cover 23,547 hectares or 22.4% of the National Park area and thus make a significant contribution to the landscape character and wildlife habitat of the National Park. 90% of the woodland is in active management and this reflects the role and employment opportunities that productive forest management provides across the National Park.
- 6.12.2 In terms of diversity, 84% of this tree cover is mapped as conifer woodland, 14% as predominantly broadleaved and 2% as mixed woodland. Just over 700 hectares of ancient and semi-natural woodland remains and as such, to promote greater diversity, disease resilience and wildlife habitat opportunity, the Authority actively encourages the expansion of native broadleaved woodland and seeks to ensure that all woods and forests are managed in line with the requirements and guidance set out in the UK Forestry Standard (UKFS).
- 6.12.3 It is recognised that there is work required to bring some of the older forestry plantations in line with the requirements and guidance set out in the UKFS and in so doing new infrastructure such as forest roads, bridges and quarries that are often required for this to happen will be subject to development guidelines.
- 6.12.4 Trees are also an important part of the National Park's living landscape and they often represent important cultural features or landmarks. As they age and become hollow, they provide particular niche habitats which support many species including owls, woodpeckers, other hole nesting birds and bats. Ancient and veteran trees may be a surviving component of a former hedgerow, indicating previous land use; or represent boundary markers on an ancient woodland bank. In situations where the Authority is made aware of an activity that may cause harm to such trees then steps may be taken to seek to formally protect them by use of a Tree Preservation Order.
- 6.12.5 Woodland, traditional orchards and hedgerows are also integral to the landscape character of the National Park, providing valuable habitats for wildlife as well as delivering environmental benefits such as carbon storage, flood risk management and opportunities for recreation. There will be a presumption in favour of the retention of all trees and hedgerows of value and in considering development proposals the Authority will look at the ecological, visual, amenity and landscape value of existing trees and hedgerows on site.
- 6.12.6 The retention of existing healthy trees is an effective way of integrating new development into the landscape. In the majority of cases development will be able to be sited so as to retain trees, hedgerows or woodland which are of value within a scheme. In appropriate cases, applicants will be required to provide a detailed tree survey and arboriculture impact assessment to show the location, species, canopy size and root system spread of existing trees and the impact of the proposed work, including any work to underground services.
- 6.12.7 In addition applicants may be required to provide a method statement, tree protection plan and management plan to ensure that trees are protected during construction works and managed appropriately thereafter. Where the loss of particular features cannot be avoided and is justified by wider sustainability benefits, the Authority will require replacement planting on site, normally using native species, which provides a net biodiversity and amenity gain. Applicants should refer to British Standard recommendations when drawing up proposals for appropriate net gain. Emphasis will be placed on the protection of areas of ancient woodland and ancient or veteran trees.

Policy DM12: Trees, Woodlands and Forests

1. In order to maximise the social, economic and environmental opportunities that trees, woodlands, and forests present, support will be given to development proposals which are not detrimental to other semi natural habitats and which:
 - a) Protect and enhance the character and nature conservation value of native trees and semi natural ancient woodlands;
 - b) Include native tree planting in appropriate locations where landscaping is required as part of the development;
 - c) Contribute to the target to increase the proportion of native woodland in appropriate areas of the National Park;
 - d) Promote the sustainable recreational, economic and environmental use of woodlands and forests; and
 - e) Support appropriate, sensitively located small-scale forestry-related development.
2. Trees will be considered for protection under a Tree Preservation Order where the tree(s) are considered to bring significant amenity benefit to the local area, including their contribution to the local landscape and biodiversity value. An Order will only be served where it would be expedient and where there is a clear risk to the tree.
3. There will be a presumption in favour of the retention and enhancement of existing trees, woodland, traditional orchards and hedgerows of value on all proposed developments.
4. Where a development would result in the unavoidable loss of an existing tree, orchard or hedgerow but the wider sustainability benefits of the development significantly outweigh the loss, proposals will be expected to minimise harm and provide a net biodiversity and amenity gain, with appropriate replacement of lost trees or hedgerows.
5. Development will not be permitted that would lead to loss of or damage to ancient woodland and aged or veteran trees found outside ancient woodland unless the need for, and benefits of the development in that location clearly outweigh the loss.



North Tyne valley © David Taylor, NNPA.

Renewable Energy

- 6.13.1 The UK has legal commitments to cut greenhouse gases and meet our increasing energy demands from renewable sources. Targets for reductions in carbon emissions of 80% by 2050 relative to 1990 levels have been embedded in law. The Government's Vision for National Parks says we should be "leading the way in adapting to, and mitigating climate change"⁶¹. The National Planning Policy Framework explains that all communities have a responsibility to help increase the use and supply of renewable energy, but this does not mean that the need for renewable energy overrides environmental protections and the planning concerns of local communities.
- 6.13.2 Capacity studies reveal that there are significant physical, infrastructural and environmental constraints on renewable energy in the National Park⁶². These result in assumptions that the National Park will only contribute very modestly to regional and sub-regional capacity through microgeneration technologies, chiefly small scale wind, solar, hydro and biomass technologies. The National Park's main contribution to national targets will be through its carbon 'sinks' – forests, woodlands and huge areas of peatland, which absorb carbon from the atmosphere. Nonetheless, the Authority wants to see greater take up of small-scale renewable and low carbon technologies. With no mains gas supply, energy choices are already quite restricted in the National Park. Reliance on expensive domestic oil, liquid petroleum gas and solid fuels to heat properties has left many households vulnerable to fuel poverty, and has a negative effect on the viability of local businesses, especially farms.
- 6.13.3 The National Park has the potential to contribute to the reduction in energy demand, and the supply of renewable energy at a household or community level. It is not an appropriate location for large scale energy development aimed at power generation to support national and regional energy supply. Wind energy and solar photovoltaic farm development in particular can significantly harm the National Park's Special Qualities.
- 6.13.4 New development should take a 'fabric first' approach and aim for a building to be as efficient as possible through good design and construction which exceeds Building Regulations where possible. The building should be at its most efficient before renewable energy 'bolt-ons' are considered. NNP has a high proportion of traditional properties built of solid wall construction, and no mains gas supply. These 'hard to treat' homes are difficult to make energy efficient and it means that the potential energy efficiency of existing housing stock is limited. Small-scale renewable energy can do much to improve efficiency, but should be considered alongside other cost-effective improvements where these are suitable, such as wall insulation and draught proofing.
- 6.13.5 Small scale renewable energy development which meets the energy demands of a single property or local community can be achieved without impacting on the National Park's Special Qualities. There is potential for micro-hydro generation, in locations where biodiversity impacts can be avoided. A range of domestic scale renewable energy facilities can be installed without the need for planning permission, and ground source and air source heat can be a relatively low impact source of renewable energy where a building is already at its most energy efficient. In some instances this can be achieved on a larger community scale to provide renewable energy without impacting on the National Park's Special Qualities.

⁶¹ English National Parks and the Broads UK Government Vision and Circular 2010. Defra. March 2010

⁶² Northumberland National Park Infrastructure Plan (2017)

6.13.6 There will be a presumption against proposals for large-scale low carbon and renewable energy development unless it can be clearly demonstrated that they will be compatible with the special qualities of the National Park, its communities and businesses and must comply with Policy ST3 (Major Development). This policy focuses on supporting take up of small-scale schemes that will reduce costs and generate revenue for local communities and businesses. It contains a presumption against large-scale commercial schemes that would be incompatible with the area's Special Qualities.

Policy DM13: Renewable Energy

1. Development proposals for small-scale schemes for the generation of renewable energy will be permitted where:
 - a) It is of a scale and design appropriate to their locality;
 - b) Renewable and low carbon technologies are incorporated into the design of new development proposals where appropriate (including for example on-site power storage, wind turbines, PICO-hydro or electric-car charging points).
 - c) It respects the existing landscape character type as defined in the Northumberland National Park Landscape Character Assessment;
 - d) It does not result in an unacceptable adverse impact on the special qualities of the National Park, either on its own, or in combination with other schemes;
 - e) It does not unacceptably impact natural resources, including river flow.
 - f) It provides environmental enhancement or community benefits wherever possible;
 - g) It makes provision for the removal of the facilities and reinstatement of the site, should it cease to be operational.
 - h) Any planning impacts identified by the affected local community have been sufficiently addressed.
2. There will be a presumption against proposals for large-scale low carbon and renewable energy development unless it can be clearly demonstrated that they would:
 - a) be compatible with the special qualities of the National Park;
 - b) meet the needs of local communities and businesses;
 - c) be supported by the local community; and
 - d) be in accordance with Policy ST3 (Major Development).



Whiteburnshank © NNPA.

Historic Environment

- 6.14.1 The Government's vision and policies for the historic environment recognise the central role it plays in cultural heritage and the multiple ways it supports and contributes to the economy, society and daily life and that it is a non-renewable, resource⁶³. Government places a priority on the conservation of heritage assets in a manner appropriate to their significance, and their value to current and future generations⁶⁴.
- 6.14.2 The historic environment is the physical remains of past human activity, whether visible or buried known or yet to be discovered, the product of human interaction with the nature and landscape over millennia. It is a rich and diverse part of Northumberland National Park's cultural heritage. This includes archaeology, the material remains of the past, from prehistory to the present day and historic buildings and structures, which include grand country houses to the distinctive bastles of the Border Reivers, historic villages, farmhouses, barns, workers cottages, limekilns, milestones and boundary stones.
- 6.14.3 The historic environment contributes to the overall landscape character. The historic landscape is shaped by the interaction of people with nature. This cultural heritage gives meaning to place and is given meaning by people, often inspired by nature, it inspires culture. It is an indelible part of our human story, best understood at a landscape scale, and is highly regarded and valued by communities and visitors alike, providing attractive places to live, work and visit.
- 6.14.4 This historic environment provides the evidence for past ways of life, technologies and the exploitation of the natural resources. The National Park's historic landscape includes thousands of individual sites and structures, and the preservation of sites is generally good. The survival of such a remarkable record of landscape change is very rare in England.
- 6.14.5 The high quality of the cultural heritage and historic environment are part of what attracts people to visit the National Park, and is therefore an important part of the local economy. However, these resources are also fragile, vulnerable to insensitive change and, ultimately irreplaceable. The protection and enhancement of Northumberland National Park's cultural heritage and historic environment is consequently a high priority. The historic character of buildings and settlements is easily eroded by small incremental changes over time, as well as by new development and insensitive modernisation, for example; unsightly overhead wires, or the removal of traditional fabric. Similarly, the quality and character of historic buildings can easily be destroyed by unsympathetic or inappropriate renovation, repair, extension, redevelopment, or simply by neglect. The National Park Authority places a high priority on protecting and enhancing cultural heritage and historic environment and the planning policies set out in this Plan seek to achieve this aim.

Heritage Assets

- 6.14.6 Heritage assets are the significant buildings, monuments, sites, places, areas or landscapes within the historic environment which are identified because of their heritage interest. They contribute to our society, knowledge and culture and therefore merit consideration in planning decisions. The significance of a heritage asset is based on its value to current and future generations, and is the

⁶³ DEFRA (2010) English National Parks and the Broads UK Government Vision and Circular

⁶⁴ NPPF section 16 (MHCLG 2019)

sum of its architectural, historic, artistic or archaeological interest and its setting. Some heritage assets have a level of significance that justifies special protection measures through designation and legislation, but locally valued (non-designated) assets also have historic interest and play a key role in defining place and in building local pride.

- 6.14.7 Whilst the protection of listed buildings is paramount, it is recognised that historic buildings have been altered and extended over time and that the need for change will continue and may sometimes be necessary to ensure their use is maintained. This may include adaptation or re-use to take account of climate change or bringing the building back into viable use. Any proposals for alteration, repair, extension (including internal works or works within the curtilage) or changes of use must be compatible with the listed building's historical or architectural interest. The character of a listed building is linked to its setting, and development proposals which adversely affect settings will not be permitted. The maintenance and use of heritage assets should make a positive contribution to local character and distinctiveness⁶⁵.
- 6.14.8 Hadrian's Wall was built around the year 122 AD and constituted the main element in a controlled military zone across northern Roman Britain. The Wall was supplemented by the ditch and banks of the vallum, supporting forts, marching camps and other features in a wide area to the north and south, linked by an extensive road network. Hadrian's Wall World Heritage Site (WHS) was designated in 1987. World Heritage Sites are places of 'Outstanding Universal Value' (OUV), recognised as such under the terms of the 1972 World Heritage Convention.
- 6.14.9 While a WHS is an international designation, it is the responsibility of national governments to ensure that the Outstanding Universal Value is maintained. However the designation itself brings no additional statutory controls over and above those afforded through the planning system and through other designations that cover elements of the WHS. Much of the length of the Wall and its associated forts and surrounding settlements are however scheduled monuments, and protected as such. The planning controls that apply to these assets are an important part of the recognition and protection of the OUV of the World Heritage Site. The remaining elements, (often the less obvious surface features) rely for their protection on the application of criteria-based policies and a precautionary approach applied across the WHS itself and a surrounding 'buffer zone'.
- 6.14.10 The Hadrian's Wall Management Plan informs such decisions, as well as the day to day management of the whole extent of the WHS, its buffer zone and its wider landscape setting. Its primary objective is to secure the identification, protection, conservation, presentation and transmission to future generations of the Outstanding Universal Value of the WHS.

Understanding Significance

- 6.14.11 Significance is the value of a heritage asset to this and future generations because of its heritage interest (archaeological, architectural, artistic or historic). Significance can be affected not only by development which has a direct effect upon it, such as physical changes to a Listed Building, but also by development which affects its setting.

⁶⁵ English Heritage (2015) Historic Environment Good Practice Advice Note 1: The Historic Environment in Local Plans

- 6.14.12 Understanding the significance of an asset is crucial in order to make informed decisions. All proposals affecting a heritage asset must be accompanied by a 'Heritage Statement' which identifies its significance. If there is insufficient information to enable the Authority to assess the impact of the proposal on the significance of the asset or insufficient justification to outweigh any harm to the asset the Authority will refuse consent.
- 6.14.13 Historic England provides useful advice and guidance on the assessment of significance and in particular "Conservation Principles, Policies and Guidance" (April 2008). Information on many heritage assets can also be found on the Authority's Historic Environment Record.

Optimal Viable Use

- 6.14.14 Sustaining heritage assets in the long term often requires investment and putting heritage assets to a viable use is likely to enable the maintenance necessary for their long-term conservation. Certain heritage assets may have limited or no scope for new uses or may be so sensitive to change that alterations to accommodate a viable use would lead to an unacceptable level of harm and loss of significance.
- 6.14.15 It is important that any use is viable, not just for the owner, but also the future conservation of the asset. The optimum viable use may not necessarily be the most profitable one, but is instead the use which causes least harm to the significance of the heritage asset(s).

Historic Environment Record

- 6.14.16 Information on identified heritage assets is available on the Authority's Historic Environment Record (HER). However, this is not a definitive record of all heritage assets in the National Park. Many assets are yet to be identified or properly understood. Applicants should therefore ensure that they consider the heritage implications of all proposals regardless of whether a heritage asset has been previously identified, as new assets may be identified during the heritage assessment phase.



Alnham Church © Paul Buxton, NNPA.

Policy DM14: Historic Landscape Assets and Built Heritage

1. Development affecting historic landscape assets of the National Park will be required to conserve and enhance landscape quality and character by taking into consideration the elements which contribute to its significance.
2. Where development will impact on features which contribute to the historic landscape the Authority will seek to preserve the features in situ. When in situ preservation is not justified the applicant will be required to make adequate provision for recording in advance of the development, secured through a Written Scheme of Investigation.
3. Development affecting the built heritage of the National Park should reinforce its distinctive historic character by fostering a positive and sympathetic relationship with traditional local architecture, materials and construction. High standards of design will be promoted to conserve and enhance the built heritage, settlement layouts and distinctive historic, cultural and architectural features. Development proposals will be supported where they:
 - a) Conserve, enhance or better reveal elements which contribute to the significance of the heritage asset or its setting including key views, approaches and qualities of the immediate and wider environment that contribute to its value and significance;
 - b) Preserve and enhance the special character and appearance of settlements including buildings, open spaces, trees and other important features that contribute to visual, historical or architectural character;
 - c) Reinforce the distinctive qualities of settlements through the consideration of scale, height, massing, alignment; design detailing, materials and finishes;
 - d) Respect the integrity of the form of historic settlements including boundary and street patterns and spaces between buildings;
 - e) In the case of new uses, ensure the new use represents the optimal viable use of the asset which is compatible with its conservation;
 - f) In the case of adapting assets for climate change mitigation, the proposal is based on a proper understanding of the asset and its material properties and performance.Development should not harm the heritage value of any assets affected.
4. When in situ preservation is not justified or the form and appreciation of a heritage asset is compromised through the proposal, the applicant will be required to undertake an appropriate programme of historic building recording (HBR) and analysis secured through a Written Scheme of Investigation (WSI).
5. Development proposals that unacceptably harm the setting of the Frontiers of the Roman Empire: Hadrian's Wall World Heritage Site (WHS) will not be permitted. Proposals within the extent of the WHS or its setting should, where possible, seek opportunities to sustain and better reveal the significance of its Outstanding Universal Value (OUV) as set out in the adopted Statement of OUV and informed by World Heritage Site Management Plan, including seeking to protect and, where appropriate, enhance:
 - a) Evidence of the scale and complexity of the Wall and its associated frontier features;
 - b) The group value of features, including features beyond the World Heritage Site;
 - c) The setting; and
 - d) Communal values including educational and recreational.

Archaeological Heritage

- 6.15.1 The National Park has over 400 Scheduled Ancient Monuments. Policy DM14 includes criteria for development proposals affecting heritage assets with archaeological interest. Archaeological sites are a finite and irreplaceable resource that helps us to understand our past. Archaeological heritage assets of regional and local significance may collectively constitute a nationally important cultural landscape. They can however easily be damaged or destroyed by development, and once lost cannot be replaced. The most significant known archaeological heritage assets are designated as Scheduled Monuments and are of national importance and have statutory protection. It is widely recognised that there are sites which have equal significance, but which are non-designated heritage assets. If the significance of such sites have been demonstrated they will be treated in the same way as Scheduled Monuments.
- 6.15.2 In addition, there are many other archaeological sites which do not have such a great significance but which form a valuable part of the National Park's heritage. Information on known archaeological sites and monuments is available on the Authority's Historic Environment Record (HER). However, this is not a definitive record of all archaeological remains in the National Park. Many assets are yet to be identified or properly understood. Applicants should therefore ensure that they consider the heritage implications of their proposals regardless of whether archaeological remains have been previously identified, as new sites may be identified during the heritage assessment phase.
- 6.15.3 The significance of assets should be established through a desk-based assessment and where necessary field evaluation to identify necessary mitigation measures to be set out within a Written Scheme of Investigation in accordance with the professional standards of the Chartered Institute for Archaeology (CIfA). Information from this investigation and recovered archaeological assets should be made available as appropriate, for public understanding and appreciation.

Policy DM15: Archaeological Heritage

1. Development that would result in harm to the significance of a Scheduled Monument or other nationally important archaeological site will not be permitted.
2. The preservation of other archaeological sites will be an important consideration having regard to their significance. When development affecting such sites is acceptable in principle, the Authority will seek the preservation of remains in situ, as a preferred solution. When in situ preservation is not justified, the applicant will be required to make adequate provision for excavation and recording in advance of development, secured through a Written Scheme of Archaeological Investigation.
3. The Authority will require applicants to provide sufficient information to allow an informed assessment of the significance of the archaeological heritage asset and its setting, and the impact of the proposed development on that significance.

Minerals and Waste

Minerals

- 6.16.1 Minerals are essential to provide the infrastructure, buildings, energy and goods which may be needed locally, nationally or internationally. The National Park produces an amount of primary minerals for use in the construction industry. There is currently only one operational crushed rock quarry within the National Park that has extant planning permission for mineral extraction⁶⁶.
- 6.16.2 National planning policy requires that Mineral Safeguarding Areas (MSAs) are defined in Local Plans to identify the total area covered by a mineral resource. The purpose of MSAs is to prevent the sterilisation of resources by alternative development. There is, however, no presumption that the resource identified within the MSA will be worked.
- 6.16.3 In compliance with national planning policy areas of the National Park have been identified as MSAs. The identification of a MSA would not however presume in favour of extraction or override international or national landscape, heritage or nature conservation designations. It is merely recognition that a mineral resource exists and that regard should be had to its long term protection. Not all of the deposits shown on the policies map are of sufficient thickness, or appropriately located, to ever be realistically workable.
- 6.16.4 Minerals development differs from other types of development in that minerals are a finite natural resource which can only be worked where they are found. Furthermore minerals operations may go on for many years, with potential benefits and impacts seen both during and after the mineral working. Mineral development includes exploration, minerals extraction, the extension of existing workings, extensions of time for working, ancillary minerals operations, or alterations to rates of extraction, mineral waste tipping, and re-working of tips.
- 6.16.5 The following policies will be used to decide applications for minerals development in the National Park. Importantly, whilst this section constitutes the Minerals Local Plan for the National Park, these policies are not the only considerations for minerals applications, and a range of other policies in this Plan will likely be relevant, this includes in particular those policies relating to landscape, biodiversity, geodiversity, heritage, tranquillity, traffic, and amenity. Major minerals development applications would be considered to be major development and have to comply with Policy ST3. Small scale minerals development (as referred to in parts 2 and 3 of Policy DM16) is considered to be any 'non-major' minerals development or the extension of time for major sites.

New or Extended Minerals Operations

- 6.16.6 Major minerals development can have a significant and irreversible impact and is not considered appropriate in the National Park other than in exceptional circumstances. The environmental impact of minerals operations has improved significantly in recent years, though, and where existing infrastructure and mitigation is in place the extension of existing operations can be the most efficient and reasonable approach to sustaining a source of minerals. It is important in considering applications for extensions (in time or scale) to carefully assess the ongoing impact of the operation and the need for it to take place within a National Park.

⁶⁶ Joint Local Aggregate Assessment for County Durham, Northumberland and Tyne & Wear (April 2018).

- 6.16.7 There exists within the National Park a resource of different building stones which have had significant use, within the National Park and more widely, in the past. This resource can support the positive conservation and design strategies for the National Park, as well as having economic benefits. In particular the reopening of an old quarry, operating at a small scale, to provide materials for the conservation of historic buildings and structures, and supporting high quality modern design in the National Park may be possible without having a significant impact.

Minimising the Impact of Minerals Operations

- 6.16.8 Parts of the National Park's landscape has been characterised by the exploitation of its natural resources in the past. This includes a legacy of historic small-scale minerals workings such as whinstone, limestone and sandstone, granite quarrying, which now form part of Northumberland's historic landscape character. Historic minerals sites could potentially offer opportunities for new commercial uses, recreation or habitat restoration as well as gradual reclamation by flora and fauna and return to a more natural state.
- 6.16.9 Minerals sites which are no longer in use should therefore be the subject of a restoration and aftercare strategy which identifies the most appropriate use for that site. That after-use will be depend upon a number of factors, including the location of the site and surrounding land uses, its scale and form, its hydrology, and risks relating to stability or contamination.



Brough Law © David Taylor, NNPA.

Policy DM16: Minerals Development

1. Proposals for major minerals development will be considered under the terms of Policy ST3.
2. The small scale expansion of existing quarries, or extension of time for minerals operations, will be permitted where it can be demonstrated that the socio-economic benefits of the development outweigh any impact upon the National Park's Special Qualities and where the proposal would accord with other relevant local plan policies.
3. Small scale quarrying of traditional building stone will be permitted where it is demonstrated that there is an identified local need for the stone which will conserve, maintain or enhance the fabric or character of the National Park.
4. In all minerals development applications reasonable mitigation measures must be provided for in the proposal, in order to minimise negative environmental and socioeconomic impacts and ensure the proposed operations do not have unacceptable adverse effects on the natural and historic environment or human health.
5. For all proposals for new or extended mineral operations, planning applications must be supported by:
 - a) evidence of the presence of the mineral;
 - b) Information relating to the need for the mineral, at a local, regional and/or national level;
 - c) Details of the proposed working methods;
 - d) Details of any proposed mitigation measures; and
 - e) An assessment of the effects of the proposal on:
 - i) assets of natural or cultural value;
 - ii) levels of noise, dust and vibration;
 - iii) amenity and a loss of privacy;
 - iv) dark night skies and tranquillity;
 - v) landscape character and visual intrusion;
 - vi) habitats and species and geodiversity;
 - vii) traffic and air quality;
 - viii) water quality, quantity, flood risk and drainage;
 - ix) land resource, including agricultural land, access land and public rights of way;
 - x) soil, contamination and land instability; and
 - xi) the economy.
6. Applications must include a proposed restoration and aftercare strategy which sets out:
 - a) how the proposed after-use responds to the site and its surroundings;
 - b) the removal of plant and other infrastructure, final landform and retained features, reinstatement of soils, and landscaping and planting proposals;
 - c) where applicable, any use of waste or other imported materials for restoration purposes;
 - d) phasing arrangements including avoidance of sterilisation of remaining resources; and
 - e) a programme of aftercare and monitoring of the site for a minimum of five years following completion of restoration.

Safeguarding Northumberland National Park's Mineral Resources

- 6.17.1 Minerals are a finite resource and it is the role of the planning system to manage the demand for land and different development types sustainably. Minerals Safeguarding Areas are shown on the policies map. The purpose of a Minerals Safeguarding Area is to ensure that the ability remains to extract a minerals resource, by ensuring that non-minerals development does not take place where it may sterilise or constrain potential future minerals working. Safeguarding of minerals should not be taken as a presumption that permission would be granted in the future for minerals development. It does however ensure that the opportunity for minerals development is not prejudiced through inappropriate land uses or development.
- 6.17.2 In considering proposals for non-mineral use of these areas we will take into account opportunity for prior extraction (where reasonable and feasible), potential non-sterilising land uses, or may decide not to grant permission where development may prejudice future minerals extraction. The following areas are identified on the Policies Map as Minerals Safeguarding Areas:
- Harden Quarry
 - Cop Crag Quarry
- 6.17.3 The designation as MSAs simply reflects the underlying geology and will not have implications for the vast majority of development proposals in the National Park, which are generally small in scale and located in settlements and other building groups where the mineral resource has already been sterilised.

Policy DM17: Minerals Safeguarding Areas

1. Important mineral resources and reserves, as identified on the Policies Map, shall be safeguarded from development which, by virtue of its siting or nature, would prevent or obstruct potential future mineral development or associated operations at that site should a clearly justified need arise to extract them.
2. Planning permission will be granted for non-mineral development within Minerals Safeguarding Areas where:
 - a) the location of the proposal relates to a settlement recognised by Policy ST4; or
 - b) the proposal can demonstrate that it will not affect the overall value of the mineral resource; or
 - c) the mineral can be extracted satisfactorily prior to the development taking place; or
 - d) the development is of a temporary nature, can be completed and the site restored to a condition that does not inhibit extraction within the timescale that the mineral is likely to be needed; or
 - e) there is an overriding need for the development.

Waste

- 6.18.1 Northumberland National Park Authority is the waste planning authority for the National Park. Responsibility for waste management within the National Park rests with Northumberland County Council. There is also a close cross-boundary relationship with the County Council as the surrounding waste planning authority. Given the small population and level of economic activity within the National Park compared with Northumberland as a whole, waste arising within the National Park is accounted for in the Northumberland Waste Plan. There is policy provision for sufficient waste facilities to be delivered outside the National Park to meet its waste needs.
- 6.18.2 There are no operational waste disposal sites in the National Park and little evidence of demand or need⁶⁷. Much of the organic agricultural waste has traditionally been disposed of through land spreading. However, as technology develops, there is increasing scope for small-scale, on-farm anaerobic digestion plants as an alternative means of dealing with livestock wastes. Such plants can reduce the risks posed by diffuse pollution as well as generating useful electricity or heat. This can be a valuable form of farm diversification - providing additional income to support the viability of farm businesses (Policy DM7), but could also be part of other commercial operations, subject to the scale restrictions set out in Policy DM13 (Renewable Energy).
- 6.18.3 Whilst this is the case it is still appropriate that within the National Park all opportunities are taken to prevent waste and enable re-use and recycling in accordance with the waste hierarchy. The following waste policies will be used to decide applications for waste development, or larger scale development with opportunities for the prevention of waste. The design of new development needs to include space for the storage of waste and recycling, in accordance with the latest regulations and guidelines. Importantly, whilst this section constitutes the Waste Local Plan for the National Park, these policies are not the only considerations for waste development, and a range of other policies in this Plan will be relevant. This includes in particular those policies relating to landscape, tranquillity, biodiversity, cultural heritage, transport, and amenity. Waste applications may also be considered to be major development in respect of Policy ST3 (Major Development).

Policy DM18: Waste Management

1. All new development should seek to prevent waste, and must identify sufficient and convenient space for storage of waste and recycling.
2. Applications for major development must include a waste audit statement demonstrating how the demolition, construction and operational phases of the development will minimise the generation of waste and provide for the management of waste in accordance with the waste hierarchy, including:
 - a) sustainable procurement in construction phase; and
 - b) methods for limiting the generation of waste and maximising recycling in construction phase.

⁶⁷ North East England Waste Arisings and Waste Management Capacity Study (2012)

Policy DM19: Waste Disposal and Recycling Facilities

1. New waste management facilities or disposal sites will not be permitted unless they can demonstrate significant environmental benefits for Northumberland National Park.
2. Small scale community-based reuse, recycling and composting facilities will be supported where they are located on a site within or adjoining the community they serve, and provide principally for waste arising in that community. Facilities should maximise the opportunity for the use of previously developed land.
3. In all cases development must mitigate against environmental and socioeconomic impacts.



Heather on moorland at Darden © *David Taylor NNPA*.

7. Glossary of Terms

Term	Definition
Affordable housing	Housing for sale or rent, for those whose needs are not met by the market (including housing that provides a subsidised route to home ownership and/or is for essential local workers); and which complies with one or more of the following definitions: a) Affordable housing for rent: meets all of the following conditions: (a) the rent is set in accordance with the Government's rent policy for Social Rent or Affordable Rent, or is at least 20% below local market rents (including service charges where applicable); (b) the landlord is a registered provider, except where it is included as part of a Build to Rent scheme (in which case the landlord need not be a registered provider); and (c) it includes provisions to remain at an affordable price for future eligible households, or for the subsidy to be recycled for alternative affordable housing provision. For Build to Rent schemes affordable housing for rent is expected to be the normal form of affordable housing provision (and, in this context, is known as Affordable Private Rent). b) Starter homes: is as specified in Sections 2 and 3 of the Housing and Planning Act 2016 and any secondary legislation made under these sections. The definition of a starter home should reflect the meaning set out in statute and any such secondary legislation at the time of plan-preparation or decision-making. Where secondary legislation has the effect of limiting a household's eligibility to purchase a starter home to those with a particular maximum level of household income, those restrictions should be used. c) Discounted market sales housing: is that sold at a discount of at least 20% below local market value. Eligibility is determined with regard to local incomes and local house prices. Provisions should be in place to ensure housing remains at a discount for future eligible households. d) Other affordable routes to home ownership: is housing provided for sale that provides a route to ownership for those who could not achieve home ownership through the market. It includes shared ownership, relevant equity loans, other low cost homes for sale (at a price equivalent to at least 20% below local market value) and rent to buy (which includes a period of intermediate rent). Where public grant funding is provided, there should be provisions for the homes to remain at an affordable price for future eligible households, or for any receipts to be recycled for alternative affordable housing provision, or refunded to Government or the relevant authority specified in the funding agreement.
Biodiversity	The variability among living organisms from all sources, including terrestrial, marine, and other aquatic ecosystems and the ecological complexes of which they are part. Biodiversity includes diversity within species, between species, and between ecosystems.
Brownfield land	Also known as 'previously developed land'. Land which is or was occupied by a permanent structure, including the curtilage of the developed land (although it should not be assumed that the whole of the curtilage should be developed) and any associated fixed surface infrastructure. This excludes: land that is or has been occupied by agricultural or forestry buildings; land that has been developed for minerals extraction or waste disposal by landfill where provision for restoration has been made through development control

	procedures; land in built-up areas such as residential gardens, parks, recreation grounds and allotments; and land that was previously-developed but where the remains of the permanent structure or fixed surface structure have blended into the landscape.
Climate change adaptation	Adjustments made to natural or human systems in response to the actual or anticipated impacts of climate change to mitigate harm or exploit beneficial opportunities.
Climate change mitigation	Action to reduce the impact of human activity on the climate system, primarily through reducing greenhouse gas emissions.
Community facilities	A wide range of local facilities and services accessible to members of the public including schools, libraries, local shops, healthcare facilities, places of worship, meeting halls, public houses, sports facilities and public open spaces.
Community Infrastructure Levy (CIL)	A levy allowing local authorities to raise funds from owners or developers of land undertaking new building projects in their area to fund the infrastructure needed to support development such as sporting and recreational facilities, open spaces, schools and other educational facilities, medical centres, transport infrastructure and flood defences.
Community Land Trust (CLT)	Community Land Trusts are local organisations set up and run by ordinary people to develop and manage homes as well as other assets important to that community, such as community enterprises, food growing or workspaces. The CLT's main task is to make sure these homes are genuinely affordable, based on what people actually earn in their area, not just for now, but for every future occupier ⁶⁸ .
Cultural Heritage	Cultural heritage is the legacy of physical artefacts and intangible attributes of a group or society that are inherited from past generations, maintained in the present and bestowed for the benefit of future generations. Tangible heritage includes buildings and historic places, monuments, artifacts, etc., which are considered worthy of preservation for the future. These include objects significant to the archaeology, architecture, science or technology of a specific culture.
Cumulative landscape effects	The effects of a proposal on the landscape fabric, character and quality and so concerns the degree to which the development becomes a significant or defining characteristic of the landscape, a feature in particular views, and the effect this has upon the people experiencing them.
Curtilage	There is no authoritative or precise definition of the term 'curtilage' and you should contact the Planning Team if your proposal relates to 'curtilage'. Various legal decisions have identified that in determining if land is 'curtilage' the following are considered: • the land must be an intimate association; • a small area forming part and parcel with the house or building which it contained or to which it was attached; • the kind of ground most usually attached to a dwelling house is a garden.
Designated heritage assets	Heritage assets formally designated under relevant legislation including: conservation areas, listed buildings, scheduled monuments, and historic parks and gardens.
Disturbed Land	Area of land where vegetation, topsoil, or overburden has been removed, or where topsoil, spoil and processed waste have been placed (e.g. as a result of mining activity).
Duty to co-operate	A requirement of the Localism Act for public bodies (such as neighbouring local planning authorities) to co-operate in the preparation of their plans and strategies.

⁶⁸ As defined by the National Community Land Trust Network <http://www.communitylandtrusts.org.uk/what-is-a-clt>

Ecosystems	Environments consisting of all living things in a particular area and the non-living things with which they interact such as soil, air, water and sunlight.
Ecosystem services	The benefits people obtain from nature often referred to as ecosystems. These include provision of natural resources such as food, water, and fuel; regulation by natural systems including clean water and air, fertile soils, flood control and climate regulation; cultural services such as recreation, and cultural heritage, and the basic infrastructure of life including soil formation, the water cycle and nutrients, fixation of carbon by plants and the ecosystems themselves.
Farmstead	A clear grouping of farm buildings with an existing dwelling.
Flood Risk	Identified probability of flooding from any water sources including fluvial, tidal, surface and ground water flooding.
Green/Blue infrastructure	A network of protected sites, nature reserves, green spaces and greenway linkages. The linkages include river corridors and flood plains, migration routes and features of the landscape, which are of importance as wildlife corridors. Green/blue infrastructure should provide for multi-functional uses i.e. wildlife, recreational and cultural experience, as well as delivering ecological services, such as flood protection and micro-climate control. It can refer to landscape elements on various spatial scale levels: from individual rows of trees to complete valley systems. Examples of green landscape elements are hedgerows, copses, bushes, orchards, woodlands and natural grasslands. Blue landscape elements are linked to water. They can be pools, ponds and pond systems, wadis, artificial buffer basins or water courses. Together they form the green-blue infrastructure.
Habitats Regulations Assessment (HRA)	A legal requirement to assess the impact of plans and proposals on the nature conservation importance of designated European sites.
Hamlet	An established, closely grouped number of dwellings within a contiguous built form.
Heritage assets	A building, monument, site, place, area or landscape identified as having a degree of significance meriting consideration in planning decisions, because of its heritage interest. The term heritage asset includes designated heritage assets and assets identified by the local planning authority (including local listing). Designated heritage asset: A World Heritage Site, Scheduled Monument, Listed Building, Protected Wreck Site, Registered Park and Garden, Registered Battlefield or Conservation Area designated under the relevant legislation. Non-designated heritage assets: buildings, monuments, sites, places, areas or landscapes identified as having a degree of significance meriting consideration in planning decisions but which are not formally designated heritage assets. In some areas, local authorities identify some non-designated heritage assets as 'locally listed'.
Historic environment	All aspects of the environment result from the interaction between people and places through time, including all surviving remains of past human activity, whether visible, buried or submerged, including landscape and planted flora and fauna.
Housing Market Area (HMA)	Geographic areas defined by household demand and preferences for housing. They reflect the key functional linkages between places where people live and work.
Infrastructure	Infrastructure is a wide-ranging term comprising the physical network of services and facilities that are required for an area to function properly. Infrastructure is considered to include, but is not limited to, the following: • Public transport & roads; • Flood defences;

	• Schools and other education/childcare provision; • GP surgeries and other healthcare facilities; • Community meeting places and facilities; • Social care facilities; • Energy supply and distribution; • Telecommunications, • Water and wastewater supply/disposal; • Key retail outlets; • Emergency services; • Sports and recreational facilities; • Cultural institutions like libraries and museums; • Waste processing & disposal facilities.
Landscape character type	A defined geographical zone with distinct types of landscape that is relatively homogeneous in character.
Landscape character area	Single unique areas within landscape character types, which have their own individual character and identity.
Landscape sensitivity	The degree to which a particular landscape character type or area can accommodate change without unacceptable detrimental effects on character.
Local Aggregate Assessment	A Local Aggregate Assessment is an annual assessment of the demand for and supply of aggregates in a mineral planning authority's area.
Local Centres	NNP's largest settlements which, although they are rural with small populations relative to areas outside the National Park, function as locally important rural service centres and are the most suitable locations in principle for new development of a scale that does not harm their form, setting and character.
Local needs affordable housing	Affordable housing (see definition above) which is intended to meet the needs of the local community. This includes a local connection to the National Park through residency and includes people who need to live close to their place of work.
Local Wildlife Sites (LWS)	Sites (also known as County Wildlife Sites) identified for their wildlife interest, which complement the network of nationally and internationally designated sites. These include important species-rich grassland, ancient woodland, heath and freshwater habitats of high quality or recognised because they support species of conservation importance.
Major development	Whether a proposal is 'major development' is a matter for the decision maker, taking into account its nature, scale and setting, and whether it could have a significant adverse impact on the purposes for which the area has been designated or defined.
Material planning considerations	Any consideration relevant to the use and development of land and which is taken into account in determining a planning application. The weight attached to material considerations in reaching a decision is a matter of judgement for the decision-taker; however, the decision-taker is required to demonstrate that in reaching that decision that they have considered all relevant matters.
National Nature Reserve (NNR)	Designated for their nature conservation or geological interest, with the aim of providing opportunities for the public to enjoy and experience these interests.
National Planning Policy Framework (NPPF)	The Government's planning policies for England and how they should be applied.
Natural Capital	Elements of nature that directly or indirectly produce value to people, including ecosystems, species, freshwater, land, minerals, the air and oceans.
Neighbourhood Plans	Community-led development plans prepared by parish and town councils for particular neighbourhoods, in general conformity with the strategic policies of

	this local plan, to shape future development in a local community, being supported by the majority of the neighbourhood in a local referendum.
Net Gain	Biodiversity Net Gain is an approach to development that leaves biodiversity in a better state than before. Where a development has an impact on biodiversity it encourages developers to provide an increase in appropriate natural habitat and ecological features over and above that being affected in such a way it is hoped that the current loss of biodiversity through development will be halted and ecological networks can be restored.
Open Countryside	Open Countryside in the context of Northumberland National Park is considered to be anywhere outside of the Local Centres and Smaller Villages listed in Policy ST4: Spatial Strategy. Farmsteads and hamlets are therefore considered part of the open countryside.
Planning Obligation	A legal agreement or undertaking under Section 106 of the Town and Country Planning Act 1990 that assists in mitigating the impact of unacceptable development to make it acceptable in planning terms. Planning obligations may only constitute a reason for granting planning permission if they meet the tests that they are necessary to make the development acceptable in planning terms, directly related to the development, and fairly and reasonably related in scale and kind. They can also be used to tie the occupancy of affordable housing. The use of Section 106 Agreements is affected by the Community Infrastructure Levy Regulations ⁶⁹ .
Planning Practice Guidance (PPG)	The Government's planning practice guidance that supports and informs the National Planning Policy Framework (NPPF) and how these policies are expected to be applied.
Policies Map	A map showing the areas or sites to which local plan policies apply.
Principal Residence housing	A form of market housing controlled by a mechanism, which ensures it can be lived in by anyone but only as their sole or principal residence. The aim of this mechanism is to prevent any new market housing being occupied as a second or holiday home.
Regionally Important Geological Site (RIGS)	Local, non-statutory sites identified for their geological and geomorphological interest – also referred to as Local Geological Sites.
Registered Provider	The term (private) Registered Provider of social housing is the generic name for the providers of social housing (social landlords) not covered by local authorities. This term is commonly used to describe 'housing associations' which were also referred to as Registered Social Landlords in previous editions. The term Registered Providers is defined in section 80 of the Housing and Regeneration Act 2008.
Rural exception sites	Defined in the National Planning Policy Framework as small sites used for affordable housing in perpetuity where sites would not normally be used for housing. Rural exception sites seek to address the needs of the local community by accommodating households who are either current residents or have an existing family or employment connection.
Rural land based enterprises	Rural land-based businesses are businesses that manage the land in a way that conserves the National Park's special qualities. These can be defined as: farming enterprises based on primary food production, rural estates, forestry, National Trust land, the military, mixed enterprises (e.g. with equestrian activities and/or game shooting) and other businesses that manage the land for conservation and/or recreation, which have benefits for health and well-being. Rural land-based businesses must also have a need to be located in the open countryside due to the nature of their operations.

⁶⁹ HM Government (2010) The Community Infrastructure Levy Regulations 2010 – regulations 122 and 123

Rural workers	A rural worker employed, either long-term or short-term, in agriculture, forestry or other land-based rural enterprise operating in the locality.
Section 3 Land	In NNP these are areas of moor and heath, woodland, identified by the National Park Authority whose natural beauty is particularly important to conserve as set out under section 43 of the Wildlife and Countryside Act 1981 ⁷⁰ .
Sequential visual effects	The recurrence of developments when moving through a landscape, and how these are experienced along transport routes, public rights of way and access land.
Sites of Special Scientific Interest (SSSI)	Sites designated by Natural England under the Wildlife and Countryside Act 1981. SSSIs are the country's very best wildlife and geological sites. They are important as they support plants and animals that find it more difficult to survive in the wider countryside. The protection of SSSIs is a shared responsibility between landowners, local authorities and Natural England.
Special Areas of Conservation (SAC)	Areas given special protection under the European Union's Habitats Directive, which is transposed into UK law by the Habitats and Conservation of Species Regulations 2010.
Special qualities of the National Park	Identified by the National Park Authority in the National Park Management Plan setting out the distinctive quality of the National Park's landscape, wildlife, cultural heritage, wildness, tranquillity, and dark night skies and people's understanding and enjoyment of these. The Special Qualities of Northumberland National Park are set out in the Management Plan. The 2016 Management Plan identifies these as a: • Distinctive Landscape Character • Rich Cultural Heritage • Landscape Rich in Biodiversity and Geology • True Sense of Tranquillity.
Statement of Community Involvement (SCI)	A statement setting out how Northumberland National Park Authority intends to consult and engage the public and other stakeholders on future planning policy documents, and planning applications.
Strategic Flood Risk Assessment (SFRA)	An assessment of risks from all sources of flooding (taking into account the impacts of climate change) and to assess the impact that land use changes and development in the area will have on flood risk.
Strategic Housing Land Availability Assessment (SHLAA)	A technical document that identifies a future supply of land which is suitable, available and achievable for housing development uses over the plan period.
Strategic Housing Market Assessment (SHMA)	A study to identify the future quantity of housing needed in a Housing Market Area, including a breakdown by type, tenure and size over the plan period.
Sustainability Appraisal (SA)	The process used to ensure that environmental and sustainability considerations have been integrated in the preparation of planning policy documents. The SA includes the requirements of the European Directive on Strategic Environmental Assessment to avoid unnecessary duplication. Together they play an important part in testing the soundness of the Local Plan.
Supplementary Planning Document (SPD)	A document that sets out more detailed policies in support of those contained in a local plan. It does not form part of the Development Plan, but is a material consideration on planning applications.
Sustainable development	Development which meets the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own environmental, societal and economic needs in pursuit of an improved quality of life.

⁷⁰ As amended by the Wildlife and Countryside (Amendment) Act 1985

Sustainable Rural Drainage Systems (RSUDs)	RSUDs are designed to control the quantity of run off from a development to reduce flood risk, to improve the quality of the run off, and to enhance the nature conservation, landscape and amenity value of the site's surroundings.
Sustainable transport modes	Any efficient, safe and accessible means of transport with overall low impact on the environment, including walking and cycling, low and ultra-low emission vehicles, car sharing and public transport.
Traditional building	Mostly older buildings of solid wall construction built of natural and often local materials (e.g. stone, cob, brick, lime mortar and render). In the National Park these usually predate World War II.
Travellers	Defined in the National Planning Policy for Traveller Sites; the collective name for Roma, Gypsies, Travellers and Travelling Showpeople.
Villages	A group of houses and associated buildings, larger than a hamlet and smaller than a Local Centre, situated in rural areas.
Water Framework Directive (WFD)	European Union legislation that requires all countries throughout the EU to manage the water environment to consistent standards.

8. Appendix 1

Northumberland County Council Car Parking Standards

Follows this page.

This appendix provides a copy of the Northumberland County Council parking standards as outlined in Para 6.9.3 (page 55). It provides further information and guidance to interpret and support Policy DM9 of this Local Plan. It contains the parking standards that will apply to all development in the National Park.



Ingram car park © NNPA.

Northumberland County Council Car Parking Standards

- D.1** This appendix provides further information and guidance to interpret and support Local Plan Policy DM9 and contains the standards that will apply to all development.
- D.2** Advice on site-specific works that are necessary to facilitate access to the development are not included and these must be considered separately. These matters will be covered in the Highways and Transportation Design and Delivery Guidance Supplementary Planning Document. Consistency with these standards alone is not in itself, therefore, sufficient to demonstrate that a proposal is acceptable either in transportation or planning terms.

Parking design

- D.3** The scale, location and functionality of parking for occupiers, visitors, service and delivery vehicles is important to the safe and efficient use of any development. These factors must be an integral element of the design of all development and must be considered at the outset of the design process.
- D.4** It is expected that parking to serve occupiers and residents will normally be provided off-street. This will normally be within the curtilage of a dwelling for residential developments, or within the development site for other uses. Parking for visitors and other vehicles need not be provided within the curtilage of dwellings or within a development site, but must be accounted for in the design of all schemes. This is reflected in the parking requirements described below.
- D.5** Developers should consider a range of approaches to car parking and will need to demonstrate that the most appropriate solution has been provided. Any on-street parking should be laid out so that it does not obstruct or make access to private driveways difficult.

Parking space dimensions

- D.6** A minimum standard car parking space will be 2.5 metres x 5.0 metres. For disabled car parking spaces, additional clearance of 1.2 metres will be required along all sides.

Domestic garages

- D.7** Domestic garages are often used for storage of cycles and various household articles. For garages to form part of the parking provision, they must have minimum internal dimensions of:
- 6.0 metres x 3.0 metres for a single garage; or
 - 6.0 metres x 6.0 metres for a double garage.

- D.8** These dimensions allow garages to accommodate the car and the storage of cycles and other items. Where these requirements are not met, the garage(s) will not be considered to form part of the parking provision for the purposes of assessing whether adequate provision is made.

Driveways

- D.9** Driveways are short sections from the public road to the house. Driveways shall be at least 3.0 metres wide for a single parking space or 3.3 metres if the driveway also provides the main pedestrian access or forms part of the wheelie bin route to the dwelling. Adjacent car parking spaces shall add 2.5 metres to these dimensions.
- D.10** For a standard 'up and over' garage door, the face of the garage should be a minimum of 5.6 metres from the back of the footway or from the edge of a shared footway. Driveways with gates should be 5.6 metres in length to enable the inward opening of gates. Driveways with no gates or garage door considerations, or with garage doors of a roller shutter type, must be no less than 5.0 metres in length.

Visitor parking

- D.11** Public parking shall be independently accessible and be available in perpetuity.
- Perpendicular parking bays (90 degree to aisle/road) shall measure 2.5 metres x 5.0 metres (6.0 metre aisle width or reversing distance);
 - Inline parking bays (bays run parallel to aisle/kerb line) shall measure 2.4 metres x 6.0 metres;
 - Echelon parking bays (bays run 45 degrees to aisle/road) shall measure 2.5 metres x 5.0 metres.

Parking standards

- D.12** Car parking needs to be considered as an important part of any scheme. The Council will seek to ensure car parking provision is at an appropriate level to cater for the development and visitors, whilst taking into account the location, circumstances in the surrounding area, highway safety and the availability of public transport.
- D.13** The following minimum car parking standards apply to Class C3 development countywide:

Class C3 minimum parking requirements		
Number of bedrooms	In curtilage parking	Visitor parking
1	1	1 per 4 units
2/3	2	
4/5	3	
6+	4	

D.14 The following car parking standards for other developments, other than Class C3, are an indication of appropriate parking levels for these developments, which will then be considered against the policy and on a site-by-site basis:

Indicative parking requirements (except Class C3)		
Use Class	Parking Requirement	Notes
A1 Shops	Shops up to 1000 square metres: 1 space per 50 square metres Shops over 1000 square metres: 1 space per 15 square metres Non food retail over 1000 square metres: 1 space per 20 square metres	Additional staff and delivery vehicle parking to be agreed.
A2 Financial and Professional Services	1 space per 30 square metres	
A3 Food and Drink	1 space per 10 square metres	
A4 Drinking Establishments	1 space per 10 square metres	
A5 Hot Food Takeaways	1 space per 25 square metres	
B1 Office	1 space per 30 square metres	
B2 General Industry	1 space per 50 square metres	
B8 Storage and Distribution	1 space per 200 square metres	
C1 Hotels	1 space per bedroom, 1 space per 3 staff	
C2 Residential Institutions	Residential care home/sheltered housing: • 1 space per unit, warden's accommodation or resident staff. • 1 space per non resident staff • 1 space per 3 rooms for visitors • 1 space per 4 residents for residents Retirement homes:	

Indicative parking requirements (except Class C3)		
Use Class	Parking Requirement	Notes
	1 space per dwelling 1 space per full time member of staff/residential staff	
C4 Houses in Multiple Occupation	1 space per bedroom	
D1 Non Residential Institutions	Clinics/surgeries: 1 space per doctor 1 space per 3 staff - Patients: 4 spaces per consulting room Day care services: 1 space per 1 staff 1 space per 10 clients Education: 1 space per 1 staff - Students who may drive: 1 space per 5	Visitor, bus and maintenance vehicle parking and pickup/drop off arrangements to be agreed
D2 Assembly and Leisure	Places of worship: 1 space per 10 seats Sports halls and pitches: 30 spaces per hall or pitch	
<i>Sui Generis</i>	Car showrooms: 1 space per 5 sales vehicles 4 spaces per MOT bay 1 space per member of staff	Valet and breakdown truck arrangements to be agreed.

